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தலைமைச் செயலகம்

Days of Governance



A Government for Generations

- | | | |
|---|--|--|
| Singapenn Special Task Force for Women Safety | Special Task Force for Interdiction of Narcotics and Gangs (STING) - 65 Special Task Force constituted to combat drug trafficking | 200 units of free electricity for domestic consumers using upto 500 units of electricity every 2 months |
| Thaalmaaman Thanga Mothiram Scheme
Every newborn delivered in Government Hospital will receive 1 gram gold ring
Rs.560 crore allocated | Annan's Seer Scheme
Women will be provided with 8 gram gold coin and a silk saree for their marriage
Rs.812 crore allocated | Expansion of Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Breakfast Scheme - Benefitting 15.14 lakhs additional students in Classes 6-8 across 15,414 Government and Government-aided schools. Rs.710 crore allocated |
| Vettri Tamil Nadu Investment Conclave 2026
Rs. 1 lakh crore investment | Special Incentive
Sugarcane - Rs.4,000 per tonne
Paddy - Rs.2,750 per quintal | Rs.6,000 crore crop loan waiver for farmers |
| 717 liquor shops located near educational institutions, temples and bus stands have been closed | Vettri Housing Scheme
Rs.3,500 crore allocated | Vettri Laptop Scheme for college students
Rs.2,000 crore allocated |
| Vettri Skill Training Scheme
Skill Development Training for 12 lakh students and 1 lakh youth | Vettri 150 Scheme
150 days of guaranteed employment | Modern Branded bicycles with helmets and water bottles to Class XI students in Government and Government- aided schools |
| TN-VETTRI : Rs.6,000 crore allocated annually to improve Water Supply, Solid Waste Management, Sanitation and Rural Connectivity | Vettri Magalir Goat Rearing Scheme
5 goats or sheep will be provided to disadvantaged women & transgenders | Honest & Transparent governance
Speedy Plan Approval, Faceless Property Registration |

Signature of the Director, Information and Public Relations Department



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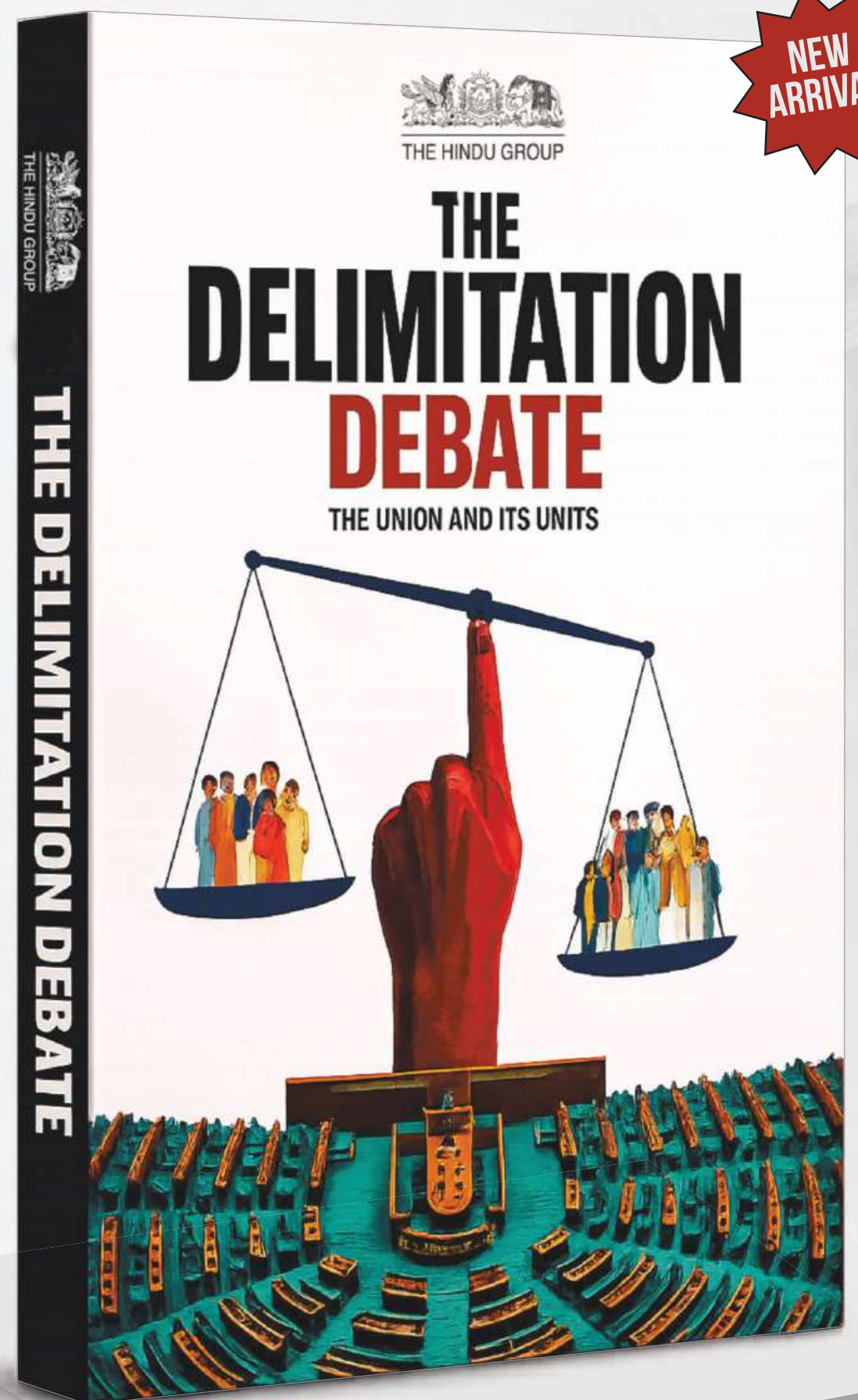
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NATIONAL SONG ROW
Amit Shah demands apology from Cong.
NEWS » PAGE 11

PHASE 2 FROM TODAY
No private data sought for Census, says official
NEWS » PAGE 10





CONTENTIOUS BILL
Sri Lanka moves to expand judges' tenure
WORLD » PAGE 14

RAPID CHANGES
India is losing West Asia, but it is not too late
New Delhi must act before its influence fades
EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



A DAY TO CHERISH
Bangladesh wins its first Test in Australia
SPORT » PAGE 15

NEARBY


Registration of exotic wildlife lags behind

CHENNAI
A large number of applications for registration of exotic animals is pending with the Tamil Nadu Forest Department, even as the State faces a shortage of facilities for housing exotic wildlife. » **PAGE 6**

Rejuvenation of ponds, channels in T.N. from today

CHENNAI
The Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department will begin the rejuvenation of 10,185 irrigation channels and 809 ponds across Tamil Nadu on Monday. » **PAGE 6**

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5, 17

Bangladesh sets ‘conditions’ for Rahman’s visit to India

Dhaka seeks ‘propitious environment’ before any visit by the PM, says relations ‘vitiated’ by Hasina’s press conference in Delhi; it calls for extradition of the deposed leader and other wanted persons

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The Bangladesh Ministry of Foreign Affairs said on Sunday that officials from New Delhi and Dhaka have been in talks for “several weeks” for a possible visit to India by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman. It also said that the atmosphere of bilateral relations has been “vitiated” by deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina’s August 5 press conference at the Foreign Correspondents Club here.

Urging India to “extradite” Ms. Hasina and the suspected killers of radical student leader Osman Hadi, the Bangladeshi Ministry’s official spokesperson, A.K.M. Shahidul Karim, said that “a propitious environment” is required for



Indian envoy Dinesh Trivedi calls on PM Tarique Rahman in Dhaka on August 10 after the former PM's press conference in Delhi. PTI

Mr. Rahman’s visit.

The official spokesperson of India’s External Affairs Ministry, Randhir Jaiswal, had reiterated last Friday that New Delhi had extended two invites to Mr. Rahman – one for the upcoming BRICS Summit to be held here and the other an invite for a bilateral vi-

sit. “We are of the view that a propitious environment needs to be created for the visit. To this end, we have requested the Indian authorities to expeditiously act on our request to extradite Sheikh Hasina and other fugitive criminals, and to hand over to Bangladesh the accused killers of Sha-

heed Sharif Osman Hadi in compliance with our bilateral extradition treaty,” said Mr. Karim in a statement, adding, “We are awaiting their response.”

Diplomatic sources had earlier indicated that bilateral talks had been on the right track after India distanced itself from Ms. Hasina’s press conference in which she had targeted Mr. Rahman’s government. Subsequently, Indian High Commissioner to Dhaka, Dinesh Trivedi, called on Mr. Rahman on August 10. In view of these exchanges, sources in Dhaka had indicated that “positive movements” had started and that the window for a big-ticket visit from Dhaka was gradually opening.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

NTA orders re-test for 3 UGC-NET papers over question errors

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The National Testing Agency (NTA) said on Sunday that it will re-conduct the University Grants Commission-National Eligibility Test (UGC-NET) for English, sociology, and commerce after finding that the papers had “defects”, which “do not meet the standards of fairness and error-free examination”.

The decision follows multiple complaints from candidates about errors in the question papers.

While the English and commerce re-exams will be held on September 9, the sociology re-test will be conducted on September 10, the NTA said. The agency had conducted the UGC-NET exam to recruit Assistant Professors and give Junior Research Fellowships, as well as for Ph.D. admissions, in 87 subjects in the last week of June. After the

The agency will hold re-exams for English and commerce on Sept. 9 and sociology on Sept. 10

exams, candidates and student groups flagged large-scale question repetitions from past years in English and commerce, alongside spelling mistakes, poor translation, and garbled scholar names in the sociology paper. “NTA has decided to re-conduct exams for three subjects after many complaints were received regarding errors in the question papers. A committee made to review these complaints came to the conclusion that the exams needed to be re-conducted,” Abhishek Singh, NTA Director-General, told *The Hindu*.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Jharkhand govt. invites protesters for talks today

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Protesting students burnt the effigies of Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on the 23rd day of their stir at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium in Ranchi, alleging that the State government was not serious about their demand for a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe into alleged irregularities in competitive exams for government jobs.

The Congress is a part of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM)-led government in the State.

Later in the day, the State government extended an invitation to the protest leaders for a fourth round of talks in Ranchi on Monday afternoon, according to a district official.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Ennore fisherfolk stage protest over mass fish deaths in river

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ennore fisherfolk held a demonstration on Sunday after large quantities of dead fish were found floating in Kosasthalaiyar river near the Ennore estuary. Officials from the Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board (TNPCB) collected water and fish samples from the affected areas for analysis.

Thousands of fish and other forms of aquatic life, including *madavai*, *kizhangan*, *oodan*, *karuva* and *kelathi*, besides prawns and crabs, were found dead in the river. The fish were seen floating across large stretches of water. They were also found along the banks, and near mangroves.



Causing concern: Dead fish floating in the Kosasthalaiyar near the Ennore estuary on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Describing the incident as an unprecedented disaster, the fisherfolk said that the deaths could be linked to the discharge of chemical waste into the river, and expressed concern over the impact on their livelihood.

Fisherfolk from eight villages blocked the Thazhan-

kuppam Main Road. Following this, Tiruvallur MLA T. Arunkumar, the Tahsildar, TNPCB officials, and an Assistant Engineer from the Fisheries Department arrived to hold talks with the protesters.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 6

‘Dimagi Naxal’ doesn’t mean Opposition, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A political row has erupted over Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s reference to “*dimagi* [intellectual] Naxals” in his Independence Day address, with Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju clarifying on Sunday that the remark was not aimed at Opposition leaders. Mr. Modi did not say Opposition leaders are “*dimagi* Naxals”, Mr. Rijiju said, noting that the Prime Minister was calling out those who “support Maoists and reject the Indian Constitution”.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 11

Armed forces to provide CAPFs with list of retiring Agniveers eligible for recruitment

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

The armed forces are likely to compile a list of Agniveers eligible for recruitment into the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) under the government’s reservation policy for the temporary recruits, a government source has told *The Hindu*.

The first batch of around 25,000 Agniveers is scheduled to retire from the Army by December.

The source added that while the CAPFs, such as the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB), and Assam Rifles, have reserved 50% of constable vacancies for former Agniveers, the



With this move, retired Agniveers may not be able to directly apply for postings in the Central Armed Police Forces. FILE PHOTO

Army, Navy, and Air Force will furnish the details of eligible personnel, indicating that ex-Agniveers may not be able to apply directly for recruitment under the reserved quota.

Although recruitment into the armed forces is not based on caste reservation,

the official said that the existing quotas for the Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, and Other Backward Classes will continue to apply for recruitment into the CAPFs.

The service tenure of personnel in the CAPFs extends up to the age of 60,

whereas those in the armed forces retire much earlier. “During deliberations, it was felt that, if given a choice, many Agniveers would prefer to join the CAPFs rather than continue in the armed forces because of the longer career span and greater job security,” the source said.

“Therefore, it has been decided, at least initially, that the armed forces, beginning with the Army, which will witness the first batch of Agniveers retiring later this year, will provide the CAPFs with a list of eligible candidates for recruitment under the reserved quota,” the source added.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

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100 DAYS | PORIBORTON AT A GLANCE

» 100 DAYS OF SHILPO

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- ₹5,000 crore Investment Promotion Framework
- Single-window clearance for investments above ₹100 crore
- ₹100 crore Startup Fund to encourage new ventures and young entrepreneurs

» 100 DAYS OF SUSHASHON

- Anti-Goonda Act brought into force
- Janatar Darbar brings people's grievances directly to the Chief Minister
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam implemented across the State
- Toll-free helpline to report bribery, extortion, illegal toll booths and illicit liquor trade

» 100 DAYS OF SURAKSHA

- 1,000+ acres transferred to the BSF to strengthen border security
- Durga Suraksha Squads and Pink Patrols patrolling streets to ensure women's safety
- Cyber Help Desks in every police station to combat cyber fraud
- Women's Police Stations in every subdivision and Women's Help Centres in every police station

» 100 DAYS OF SAMRIDDHI

- West Bengal's first Atal Incubation Centre (AIC Techno) launched in Kolkata, to nurture young entrepreneurs and startups
- Transparent OBC reservation framework ensures the annulment of the unlawful 17% reservation and ensuring a fair 7% reservation
- 2 crore+ trees already planted across the state under the Ekti Gaach Mayer Namey initiative
- New airports to come up in Purulia, Balurghat and Malda, with a second greenfield airport underway in Kalyani

» 100 DAYS OF SWASTHO

- Free treatment up to ₹5 lakh under the Mukhyamantri Swasthya Yojana
- 1.43 crore families covered under Ayushman Bharat
- 2,000-bed state-of-the-art hospital coming up in New Town, with 1,000 beds reserved for the underprivileged
- AIIMS and a state-of-the-art cancer hospital in North Bengal, along with modern state-run hospitals in the Sundarbans and Jangalmahal

» 100 DAYS OF SHOSHOKTIKORON

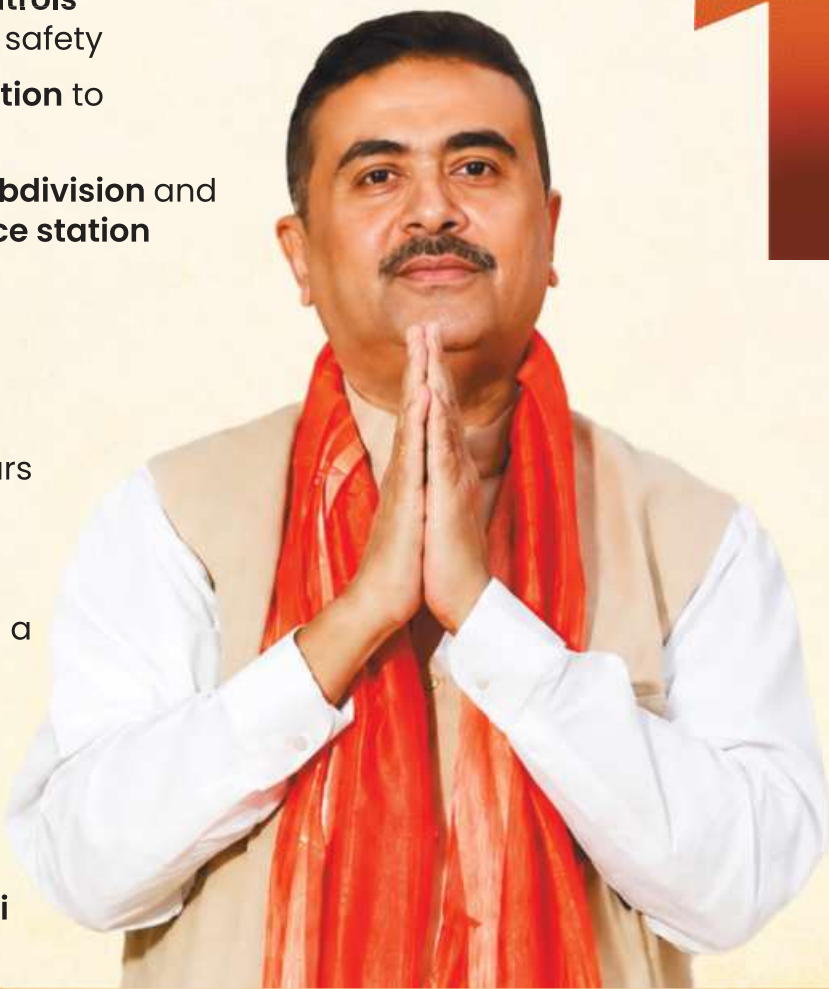
- ₹3,000 monthly credited to the bank accounts of 1.19 crore Annapurna beneficiaries
- Free travel for women on government buses
- To secure the future of the youth, work has already commenced for creating 1 lakh government jobs by the next year
- 33% reservation for women announced in government jobs

» 100 DAYS OF SIKSHA

- Higher Mid-Day Meal allocation and improved food quality in collaboration with ISKCON
- Nearly 35,000 books from libraries across West Bengal made easily accessible online
- ₹296 crore financial assistance to improve government and Bengali-medium schools
- Sanitary napkin vending machines installed in government schools; 10 lakh+ girl students covered under Kanyaratna

» 100 DAYS OF SEVA

- ₹60,000 provided to 10.20 lakh beneficiaries under Awas Yojana
- Fish and rice now served at Maa Ahar canteens
- ₹500 increase in monthly pensions for senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities
- Daily food allocation for patients in government hospitals increased from ₹56 to ₹110



DAYS OF BHOROSHA

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NEW WEST BENGAL



T. Ramasami, former secretary, Department of Science and Technology, Government of India felicitating a student at VIT, Chennai, convocation on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Youth play crucial role in shaping humanity’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The youth have an important role in building not only their own future, but also shaping their family, the country and humanity, said T. Ramasami, former secretary, Department of Science and Technology, Government of India at the 14th annual convocation of Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT), Chennai on Sunday.

“Since 2000, Tamil Nadu has emerged as a leader in research and development, as measured by the number of research papers published in peer-reviewed journals. About 61 per cent of the research papers published in India are from Tamil Nadu, of which 35 per cent are contributed by private univer-

sities,” he said. Ganesanathan Geathiswaran, Deputy High Commissioner of Sri Lanka said India and Sri Lanka were separated by a narrow stretch of water, but connected by thousands of years of history and culture.

VIT founder and Chancellor G. Viswanathan said, “While India was witnessing rapid economic growth, the expansion of higher education had not kept pace with that of developed nations.” VIT vice-presidents Sankar Viswanathan and G.V. Selvam, vice-chancellor V.S. Kanachana Bhaaskaran, provice chancellor T. Thyagarajan, Director K. Sathiyarayanan, Registrar, Jayabarathi .T. and additional registrar P.K. Manoharan, VIT Chennai took part.

Foot overbridges to be built at congested locations in city

The Greater Chennai Corporation will also establish air-conditioned bus shelters across the city. Tentative locations for these facilities are identified, says GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) will build foot overbridges at congested locations with a high footfall of commuters, across the city.

The civic body will also establish air-conditioned bus shelters across the city. GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran conducted a meeting last week to develop the facilities. “The Greater Chennai Corporation has initiated the process of engaging consultants to undertake feasibility studies for the establishment of 30 air-conditioned bus shelters and development of 20 foot overbridges across the city. Tenders for consultancy have been called for,” said Dr. Sameeran.

“Tentative locations for these facilities have been identified in consultation with the Greater Chennai Traffic Police and Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC). These loca-



Improving infrastructure: The Corporation proposes to build 20 foot overbridges across the city. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

tions will be provided to the selected consultants for detailed technical, traffic, site, and commercial feasibility assessment,” he said.

Based on the studies, the consultants will identify feasible locations and prepare appropriate financial and concession models for implementation. The projects are proposed to be implemented through a concession-based model, wherein the capital cost for construction and associated infrastructure will be invested by the concessionaire. In re-

turn, the concessionaire will be permitted to utilise the advertisement rights associated with the facilities, subject to applicable rules and regulations.

The annual concession fee offered by the bidder will be the principal bidding parameter for selection of the concessionaire.

The initiative aims to improve commuter amenities, pedestrian safety, and accessibility while leveraging private investment for creation and maintenance of modern urban infrastructure, said Dr. Sameeran.

‘Everyday life, people, and natural spaces make the city special’

Everything is special about Chennai because it is our city, the one we live in.

The city is also one we must protect and safeguard.

Celebrating Chennai must be the norm, and I believe this must happen every day, not just for a day, week or month.

It is the everyday life of the city, its people, its neighbourhoods and its natural spaces that make it special.

While it is certainly good to see community engagement through neighbourhood heritage walks and talks this month, I deeply feel it is time we also encouraged and facilitated such engagement in simple but proactive citizen actions that can bring about changes in their own neighbourhoods. After all, it is when people feel connected to their neighbourhoods and take an interest in what happens around them that



Shobha Menon, Founder, Nizhal, a Chennai-based environmental organisation

real change can begin.

I believe that great changes can be brought about through sustained and diligent local action and give us cleaner, safer, greener streets. With genuine support networks within communities, we can catalyse win-win connections

all around. That, I think, is the need of the hour, and that, I would call, a true celebration of Chennai.

(As told to Geetha Sri-mathi)

Timings
CHENNAI

MONDAY, AUG. 17		
RISE	05:57	SET 18:29
RISE	09:49	SET 21:45
TUESDAY, AUG. 18		
RISE	05:57	SET 18:29
RISE	10:39	SET 22:25
WEDNESDAY, AUG. 19		
RISE	05:58	SET 18:28
RISE	11:31	SET 23:08

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	26
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	38	27

Chennai Airport Today
36°C The weather will be very warm and uneasy. Night will also be comfortable. Chances of light rain and thundershowers.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be warm. Night will also be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershowers may occur.

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THE HINDU
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Research achieves its highest purpose when it serves society: C.P. Radhakrishnan

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan on Sunday said research achieves its highest purpose when it serves society. Indian research was being well respected in the whole world, he said.

Delivering his address at the 22nd convocation of the SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) at Kattankulathur, he said: “We never wanted to encash our research. Recalling that on the directions of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the COVID vaccine from India was sent to over 100 countries free of cost. That is the greatness of India.”

He recalled his recent meeting with the Speaker of Kenyan Parliament, who thanked India for COVID vaccine. India's COVID vac-



Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan presenting degree certificate to a student at the 22nd convocation of SRMIST at Kattankulathur on Sunday. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar and Chancellor T.R. Paarivendhar are also seen. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

cine has saved the entire humanity. India was always for peace, development, and humanity, he said.

The Vice-President appreciated SRMIST for building an academic ecosystem that promoted interdisciplinary learning, creativity, entrepreneurship, and critical thinking; its emphasis on translating research into practical so-

lutions that improve lives, strengthen industry and contribute to sustainable development.

In his speech, Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar said: “We have got a very lengthy heritage of science and technology in our country. What we require today is: we must be proud of our yesteryear's, earlier technology, earlier science.

Even if we are going ahead in today's technology, we must be proud of what we had in our ancient times.”

SRMIST Chancellor T.R. Paarivendhar; Pro-Chancellor (Administration) Ravi Pachamuthu; Pro-Chancellor (Academics) P. Sathyanarayanan; Vice-Chancellor C. Muthamizhchelvan; and other dignitaries were present on the occasion.

R. Velusamy, President - Automotives Business, Mahindra & Mahindra Limited was conferred the degree of doctor of science (*Honoris Causa*).

Across all campuses, a total of 11,684 graduates were eligible for degrees this year under the Faculty of Engineering and Technology. The Vice-President also unveiled a 32-foot statue of Founder Chancellor Dr. T. R. Paarivendhar at Vendhar Museum.

CBI re-registers BSP leader murder case following HC order

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

A special team of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Saturday visited the spot where the then Bahujan Samaj Party's Tamil Nadu president K. Armstrong was murdered.

After re-registering the case following the orders of the Madras High Court, investigators of the Special Task Branch visited the scene of crime on Venugopal Samy Street in Perambur, police sources said.

Armstrong was hacked to death by a gang near his residence in Chennai on July 5, 2024.

The case initially investigated and chargesheeted by the Greater Chennai Police was transferred to the central agency by the Madras High Court on September 24, 2025, while passing orders in a petition filed by the BSP leader's

brother K. Immanuel, who sought a CBI probe as the local police had allegedly failed to investigate the case properly. The court also quashed the 7,411-page chargesheet filed by the Greater Chennai Police in the case. The Supreme Court stayed the order of the Madras High Court after the Chennai Police Commissioner filed a Special Leave Petition (SLP) against the order.

However, the SLP was withdrawn by the State Government recently. Passing orders in the case the Supreme Court said that consequent to the dismissal of the SLP, the order dated September 24, 2025, of the Madras High Court directing quashing of the charge sheet filed by the State Police pursuant to investigation conducted in the case would remain and “the CBI will step in as the investigating agency”.

Student death over drug issue painful: Vice-President

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Calling upon students to stay away from the menace of drugs, Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan on Sunday said that it was “very painful” for him to read about the death of a college student in Coimbatore, who was killed after he passed on information about the prevalence of drugs, and further said he felt as if he had lost someone in his family.

In his address during the 22nd convocation of the SRM Institute of Science and Technology, Kattankulathur, the Vice-President said: “I also urge all of you to always stay away from the menace of drugs and all forms of substance abuse. We should not get controlled by an external force, rather our mind should get controlled by ourselves.”

New path proposed to link Radha Nagar Subway with station

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Southern Railway, along with CUMTA, has planned an alternative and safe pathway to the Chromepet Railway Station from the Radha Nagar subway side. Upon completion, the facility will provide safe and convenient entry and exit passageways for passengers accessing the station from the Radha Nagar side.

Citing the news article “Lack of safe access to platforms puts Radha Nagar residents at risk” published in *The Hindu* on Saturday, the Chennai Division of Southern Railway, in a release, acknowledged the safety concerns.

Considering the technical aspects of the subway located 120 metres away from the railway station, the Southern Railway has planned to create a new ac-

cessway, it said. While footpaths are available on both sides across the already constructed Radha Nagar subway, the railway officials have found that the subway is situated approximately 120 metres away from the platform end and has no direct connection to the railway platforms.

Providing the proposed pathway would require passengers to walk for a considerable distance along the railway tracks between the suburban tracks and fast line tracks. Such an arrangement would pose grave safety risk to passengers and is operationally unviable, it said. These technical and safety concerns were also duly brought to the notice of the Madras High Court, which subsequently disposed of the matter, directing that the representation be considered in accordance with law, it added.

Cinema under the stars



Marina Beach came alive on Sunday as the city gathered for *The Hindu* Made of Chennai's Moonlight Cinema, enjoying the screening of *Vikram* and *Theri*, by the sea. Casagrand presents *The Hindu* Made of Chennai, co-powered by AU Small Finance Bank; Associate Partner: Andhra Pradesh Tourism, Joy Alukkas, Orchid The International School, Sunfeast Supermilk; Education Partner: Hindustan Group of Institutions; Mobility Partner: Toyota; Good Food Partner: Akshaykalpa Organic; Protein Partner: Licious; Overseas Education Partner: StudyIn; Movie Partner: Kalaippuli S. Thanu presents V creations, RKFI; Radio Partner: Big FM. R. RAGU

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SCHEDULE					
Films	Star cast / Director	Lang- uage(s)	Territory	Theatrical release date	Rights
BLAST ("Original Film")	Original: Tamil				The linear rights to exploit and distribute the Film(s), including but not limited to: 1. Linear Distribution rights; 2. Terrestrial Television rights; 3. Non-exclusive Subtitling Rights in all Languages of the World including English, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam, Kannada and Hindi 4. Syndication Rights; 5. Ancillary Rights; 6. Clip Rights; 7. Door-darshan Rights; 8. Simulcast Rights 9. Dubbing Rights in all Indian Languages 10. New Exploitation Rights and New Exploitation Methods
BLAST ZONE Telugu dubbed version of the Original Film titled "BLAST"		Telugu dubbed		28th May 2026	
BLAST Kannada dubbed version of the Original Film titled "BLAST"	Star Cast: Arjun Sarja, Abhirami and others Director: Subash K. Raj	Kannada dubbed	Worldwide (India Exclusive & Outside India Non-Exclusive)	NA	Perpetual
BLAST Malayalam dubbed version of the Original Film titled "BLAST"		Malayalam dubbed		NA	
BLAST ZONE Hindi dubbed version of the Original Film titled "BLAST"		Hindi and other Indian Languages	Exclusive World	NA	
		Zulu	World non-exclusive	NA	
Dated : 17th August 2026, Place : Chennai					
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CINEMA • ARTS • EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

The Music Academy Madras
Today: 6.00 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. At the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall - The Music Academy Madras - HCL Concerts - K Aathreyee Krishna (Vocal), Sahana Sreeram (Violin), Guruvayoor Lakshman (Mridangam).

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, East Mada Street, Mylapore, Chennai-4
is celebrating "BhavaNonam" between 17- 21 August 2026
Today: 17th August: High Tea at 5.30 pm, 6.00 pm: Inauguration: **Chief Guest: Sri M.K.Narayanan**, Former National Security Adviser & Former Governor of West Bengal, **Guests of Honour: Sri Gokulam Gopalan**, Chairman Gokulam Group, Entrepreneur & Educationist, **Sri Rajiv Menon**, Indian Film Director, Cinematographer & Actor, **Sri N.Ravi**, Chairman, Bhavan's Chennai Kendra presides, Welcome address by **Dr.Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti**, 6.30 pm: **"Kathakali-Narakasura Vadham** by **Natyakala-School of Dance**. Tomorrow: **18th August** : 6.30 pm: **"Kerala Musical Ensemble"** by **Sudeep Palanad & Team**. All are Welcome.

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C Charulatha - Veena, Kaushik Sridhar, Harihara Subramaniam. Concert dedicated to Smt. Andai & Sri. V Ananthanarayanan. Today 6.15 p.m at Ragasudha Hall.

Narada Gana Sabha Trust
Ph: 24995201
Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall) Pancha Bhootha Bharatham. Theme- "Vayu - Air" 6.15 pm Talk by Dr. Sudha Seshayyan. Dancer - Christopher Gurusamy, Musician - Vignesh Ishwar. Tomorrow - Theme - "Akasa- Sky" 6.15 pm Talk by Dr.Sudha Seshayyan. 6.30 p.m Dancer- Harinee-Jeevitha, Musician- Dr. Gayathri Girish. All are welcome.

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From Page One

Ennore fisherfolk stage protest over mass fish deaths in Kosasthalaiyar

The incident comes amid long-standing concerns over pollution in the Ennore estuary and the Kosasthalaiyar.

The area has been affected by industrial effluents, sewage, coolant water, and fly ash from the concentration of industries and thermal power plants around the estuary.

Fisherfolk sought a detailed report on the nature of the effluents that had entered the waterbody, including whether they were toxic, and which industries or companies were responsible for the discharge.

“Such kind of effluent release has become a regular incident now. How can we make a livelihood by fishing if this is the case,” said Madhanagopal, a fisherman.

Demand compensation

They also sought compensation for the loss of livelihood. The fisherfolk said the estuary was an important fish-breeding area, and thousands of fish had died in the incident. They demanded compensation equivalent to one year’s livelihood, saying they had never witnessed a fish kill on this scale.

Their third demand was for employment opportunities in the industries and thermal power plants in the area. Vishanth, a local fisherman, said the community had been promised jobs when the thermal power plants were established, but only around 500 people were provided employment initially.

“Our livelihoods have already been affected by fly ash and hot coolant water,” he said. The MLA assured the protesting fisherfolk that jobs would be provided to eligible members of the local communities.

INBRIEF

Vasan condemns death of two school students in Chennai

Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) leader G.K. Vasan on Sunday condemned the recent death of two students at a State-run school at Tiruvottiyur in Chennai and called for a crackdown on illegal drugs in the State. Citing a media report, Mr. Vasan said it was the duty of the government to get to the motive behind the murder, arrest those involved, and ensure they were punished. He also called for awareness against the use of illegal drugs among school and college students.

CM condoles constable's death, announces ₹30-lakh solatium

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Sunday condoled the death of a constable who fainted while being on the Independence Day parade duty at Fort St. George in Chennai and died while under treatment. An official press release said Mr. Vijay was saddened by the death of A. Dharmaraj, a Grade-I constable attached to the Drums Bagpiper band of the Tamil Nadu Special Police Training Centre at Avadi. Dharmaraj was admitted to the Rajiv Gandhi Government General Hospital and died later. Mr. Vijay conveyed his condolences to the bereaved family and ordered payment of ₹30 lakh in relief.

SOAS varsity fellowship on SCs, STs welfare aims to take T.N. model to global audience

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A three-month-long fellowship at SOAS University of London aimed at taking the research on the Dravidian movement and social justice to a global audience is nearing completion, with its first recipient from Tamil Nadu researching Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) welfare governance in the State.

The Ambedkar-Kalaigarn Visiting Fellowship was initiated by Chennai-based technology entrepreneur V. Sabarisan and his wife, Senthamarai, daughter of former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, “with an objective to bring the Dravidian movement’s core principles of social justice, self-respect, and federalism to wider academic and policy audiences.”

Mr. Sabarisan told *The*

The fellowship has been initiated ‘with an objective to bring the Dravidian movement’s core principles of social justice, self-respect, and federalism to wider academic and policy audiences’

Hindu he had donated 170 books on the Dravidian movement and social justice to SOAS two years ago.

During a later visit to the University, he found students reading the books with interest, which prompted him to initiate this fellowship, which covers travel, visa fees, a three-month stipend, and term fees, enabling a researcher, journalist, or policymaker to develop and share their research work with an international academic audience. This

Large number of applications for registering exotic animals pending before Forest Dept.

Sources say around 2,000 applications are pending before the Chief Wildlife Warden. The process also involves an inquiry and a physical verification of the location where the animals will be kept

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

A large number of applications for registration of exotic animals is pending before the Tamil Nadu Forest Department, while the State faces a shortage of facilities for housing exotic wildlife when it is seized.

According to sources, around 2,000 applications are pending before the Chief Wildlife Warden, the final authority of approval in the State. The number of applications pending in the districts is higher as applications are first scrutinised by the district authorities before being forwarded to the Chief Wildlife Warden.

A senior official of the Forest Department confirmed that a large number of applications was pending and attributed the backlog to the transition from PARIVESH 1.0 to PARIVESH 2.0. When the new portal was introduced, several applicants had filed their applications on PARIVESH 1.0. It remains unclear whether these applications will be migrated to the new platform or fresh



Limited space: Activists say there is a lack of dedicated facilities to house exotic animals after they are seized. IMAGE USED FOR REPRESENTATIONAL PURPOSE

ones have to be filed, the official said. However, the portal transition was not the only reason, the official said, pointing out that the demand for exotic wildlife was also high. The number of applications has implications for the department’s ability to scrutinise documents and conduct physical verification of animals and facilities. Under the Living Animal Species (Reporting and Registration) Rules, 2024, possession of animals covered under Schedule IV of the Wild Life (Protection) Act has to be reported and registered. The process involves scrutiny of the application,

an inquiry, and physical verification of the facility before a registration certificate is issued.

Chief Wildlife Warden Rakesh Kumar Dogra said the scrutiny and approval of applications was a long and complex process, involving verification of the information with the Forest Departments of other States, especially in the case of species listed in the CITES Appendices. The applications were being processed in accordance with the prescribed norms.

Another challenge is the lack of infrastructure to house exotic animals after they are seized, activists

Annamalai levels graft charge against some T.N. Ministers, claims to possess audio clip as proof

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

We The Leaders founder K. Annamalai said on Sunday that some Ministers in the TVK-led government had demanded a cut ranging from 2% to 4%. But he did not name anyone. He also claimed to have an “audio” (clip) to prove his charge.

“They say corruption has stopped. We have been watching, and it has started again. It is true that Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay is against corruption. They are not getting it in major tenders. Many Ministers have just now started receiving. I even have the audio [clip]. They have

come [elected] without giving money for votes. ‘[But they are saying] We have given money for votes. So, give me 2%, 3%, 4%,’ Mr. Annamalai said, speaking at a meeting of his supporters in Chennai.

According to him, he was bringing it to the notice of Mr. Vijay now “before we rake up this issue after a year”.

Mr. Annamalai urged the Chief Minister to “bridle” his Ministers and officials. As for the functioning of the TVK government, he said, “Whether the people like it or not, a revolution has occurred in Tamil Nadu after so long. A Chief Minister has come to pow-



K. Annamalai

er. I keep saying, ‘let us give them a year’. Of the 108 MLAs, 101 are first-time MLAs.”

“Let us give them a year and let them do their job. If they do not do their job well, we will be the first one to level charges against them. They are doing so-

omething right and something wrong. When we point out the mistakes, they have corrected them too. We check the functioning of the government and give them reports. When we point out how many Tasmac shops are still within 500 metres [of educational institutions and places of worship] they take action. I would definitely appreciate it. It is a good political approach,” Mr. Annamalai said.

Pointing out that the 2026 Budget sought to save ₹15,000 crore, he urged Mr. Vijay to earmark ₹5,000 crore each for three priorities: protecting waterbodies in rural areas;

Irrigation channel, pond rejuvenation work to commence under VB-G RAM G

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department will begin rejuvenation of 10,185 irrigation channels and 809 ponds across Tamil Nadu from Monday in preparation for the Northeast monsoon.

The work will be taken up under Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) or VB-G RAM G. According to sources, desilting of waterbodies and irrigation channels, ahead of the Northeast monsoon, will help maximise rainwater storage, raise the groundwater table, and improve irrigation. It will also help control floods in times of heavy rain.

Minister for Rural Development and Water Resources N. Anand will inaugurate the work, to be carried out in 37 districts, excluding Chennai, at an estimated cost of ₹507.92 crore. Mr. Anand told *The Hindu* that the desilting of ponds, ooranis, and channels would be taken up after due measurement by surveyors. The department will coordinate with farmers, panchyat representatives, and volunteering agencies that work with

channels and water bodies and ensure the work is done properly. The payment will be done only after the work is completed. “At the same time, since in some places persons with disabilities are also part of the VB-G RAM G, we will ensure that they are not disturbed in any manner. The work will be completed by September-end, when the monsoon is likely to begin,” he said.

Since the entire work cannot be done manually, we have sought CSR funds for earth movers, and other machinery.

Farmers with whom *The Hindu* spoke, said though this was a welcome idea, VB-G RAM G workers alone would not be able to complete the work on their own. “In some villages, especially in the Delta districts, farmers come together to desilt channels. In such cases, the government’s desilting work can be clubbed with ours to make it more effective,” said Ravichandran, a farmer of Nannilam.

A total of 2,514 channels and 53 ooranies are to be desilted in Thanjavur alone. Ramanathapuram has the highest number of ponds to be desilted with 137.

CM condemns ‘killing’ of three Tamils by foresters in Karnataka

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Sunday condemned the “killing” of three Tamils by the Karnataka Forest Department in an alleged exchange of fire in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary in Chamaraajanagar district on Saturday.

In a post on X, Mr. Vijay said Anthony Sami, John Rose Peter, and Kumar from Tamil Nadu had been living in Hanur taluk of Karnataka. “They were shot dead by Karnataka Forest Department personnel in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary in the early hours of August 15. I strongly condemn this killing. The explanation given by the Karnataka Forest Department regarding the incident is unacceptable,” he said.

He also demanded an impartial inquiry and the constitution of a high-level inquiry committee.

Stalin's demand

Earlier, DMK president M.K. Stalin questioned the Chief Minister’s “silence” on the incident. He demanded compensation and government jobs for the kin of the deceased.

He alleged that there was an attempt by the Karnataka government to safeguard those involved in the killing. “It should be prevented. A case should be filed, and there should be an impartial judicial inquiry,” he said.

Correction

In the headline of the report “KKNPP has generated over 1.30 million units of power”, it should read 130.63 billion units, and not as published. The error is regretted.

‘A uniform 50% increase in LS seats is pulling the wool over someone’s eyes’

Udhav Naig
CHENNAI

Advocating against undertaking delimitation on the basis of population, Congress Rajya Sabha Member Praveen Chakravarty said on Sunday that the proposal to uniformly increase the Lok Sabha seats for all States was pulling the wool over someone’s eyes.

In an interview with *The Hindu* in Chennai, he said the Tamil Nadu Congress does not believe that the number of seats should change if the population increases.

“Tamil Nadu’s share [of Lok Sabha seats] will roughly go down to 30 seats (if we accept the seats based on population). Why should we accept being punished for our successes? The (proposed) 50% increase in seats is pulling the wool over someone’s eye. While it seems like it’s a uniform increase for everybody, let’s take Uttar Pradesh as an example. Uttar Pradesh has 80 seats,



Praveen Chakravarty

while Tamil Nadu and Puducherry combined have 40 seats. So, the difference is 40 seats. If everybody gets a 50% increase, the 40 more voices that we need to oppose will become 60 more voices. So, we are already in a minority compared to the North. Why widen this gap?” he asked.

The Congress would ensure the number of seats in Lok Sabha remains the same (543) “after 2029, when Rahul Gandhi becomes Prime Minister,” he said. Asked to reflect on the recent Gen Z protests in New Delhi against the Union government, which

resulted in the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over paper leaks, Mr. Chakravarty said the younger generation sought a radical change and doesn’t like the entrenched politics of the establishment.

“What I have observed during the Tamil Nadu election is that for the first time, it was such an age divide. Less than 40 in one direction, above 50 in another direction. Very similar to the Jantar Mantar protests. They don’t like establishment entrenched politics. And it’s really a challenge for all political parties, including my own. Fortunately, our leader, Mr. Rahul Gandhi has coped quite well,” he said.

Regarding the recent Assembly election results, which saw the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam, led by C. Joseph Vijay (now, Chief Minister), become the single largest party, and how he was one of the first to sense the ground swell of support for the TVK, the

MP said: “Anybody who was actually doing surveys honestly and were true to what they saw realised that there was a strong desire for change. And the youth divide was extraordinary. Around 60% to 70% of people below 40 are saying that they want to give this new party a chance. And the third, the DMK never in its history has won a reelection. And, there’s a reason for it. When it’s in power, it just goes berserk.”

He also said that the overwhelming support enjoyed by Mr. Vijay shouldn’t be dismissed as mere “fandom”. “The verdict basically changed all we knew about Tamil Nadu politics over the last three decades,” he said.

Commenting on the resignations of MLAs from the AIADMK who later joined the TVK, Mr. Praveen said the younger generation would not accept “political opportunism”.

(For the full video interview, visit: <https://newsth.live/PCinterview>)

INBRIEF



CJI, BCI chief must not attend convocation: NLSIU students

Students and alumni of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU), Bengaluru, have opposed the participation of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Manan Kumar Mishra, Chairman of the Bar Council of India, at their convocation. “We stand in solidarity with the NALSAR [University of Law, Hyderabad] in their request to reconsider the choice as the chief guest and express strong disapproval of the CJI attending the convocation of NLSIU,” an open letter stated.

Arunachal engineering student found dead in Kerala

A 20-year-old B.Tech. student from Arunachal Pradesh, Michi Marpu, was found dead at his rented house at Kothamangalam in Kerala, on Saturday, triggering a probe. He was a third-year student at the Mar Athanasius College of Engineering. A section of students said he was upset over the “year break system”, under which only those who scored 22 credits in Semester 4 could move to the next semester. (People in distress can contact Tele MANAS: 14416)

BJP's P. C. George retracts election fund misuse charge

BJP leader P. C. George, who had alleged that a large portion of the election funds for the party's campaign in Poonjar constituency in Kerala had been misappropriated, on Sunday withdrew the charge. Mr. George said the party leadership showed him the accounts after his speech and that he was now convinced there had been no financial irregularities. “After my speech, the party leadership showed me the accounts... I am convinced that nobody stole any money,” he said.

Woman, son held for killing two for gold

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A 38-year-old woman and her minor son have been arrested in Siddipet district of Telangana for allegedly murdering at least two women for gold.

On August 8, villagers of Ramakkapeta spotted a partially burnt body near agricultural fields. The Dubbak police registered a case and later identified the victim as a woman named Athikam Vijaya, 45, a resident of Bhoompally

village. The police used CCTV footage to identify the killers as a woman from Bhoompally and her teenaged son, who together ran a tea point. They targeted women who could be robbed and used their outlet to observe people

and gather information. The police said that on May 28, the duo murdered another woman, Kunta Rekha, and burnt her body in the Achamayyapalli forest area. The police seized property worth around ₹10 lakh.

Families withdraw protest against sanctuary firing; bodies handed over

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

The post-mortem of the three suspected poachers killed in an alleged exchange of fire in the Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary at Hanur in Karnataka was conducted at the Mysore Medical College and Research Institute (MMC&RI) in Mysuru on Sunday, only after relatives and villagers withdrew their protest. MMC&RI Dean Dr. Dakshayani confirmed that all three bodies were handed over to the families. The families had earlier refused to give their consent for the autopsy until they received a written assurance of compensation and punitive action against the officials involved. Meanwhile, the protest that began in Hanur on Saturday, intensified on Sunday. Several organisations joined a demonstration and tried to block the road to Malai Mahadeshwara Hills, demanding action against the forest staff involved in the shooting.

More compensation

Amid the tension, Hanur MLA Manjunath held discussions with the families of the deceased and eventually persuaded the protesters to withdraw the agitation. In addition to the ₹5 lakh compensation for each of the three families, the MLA promised an additional ₹10 lakh each from his personal funds.

Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said the forest staff had informed him that guns and two bags of meat of wild animals had been recovered from those killed in the shoot-out.

Omission of Vande Mataram sparks political row in Kerala

BJP says skipping it was a 'serious constitutional issue', says State has bowed to political pressure; CPI questions Cong's 'secular' credentials over full song rendition at AICC office, party-ruled States

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Vande Mataram question dominated the political debate in Kerala on Sunday, a day after the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government skipped the rendition of the National Song during the Independence Day function.

BJP State president Rajeev Chandrasekhar said the omission was a serious constitutional and legal issue. It is unacceptable for the State government to take a stand on issues related to nationalism by bowing to political pressures, he said. “Why is there a dif-



ferent approach only in Kerala when the National Anthem and National Song are part of official functions in Congress-ruled States such as Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh and Jammu and Kashmir,” he said.

BJP national president Nitin Nabin, in a post on X, said that bowing down be-

Why is there a different approach only in Kerala when the National Anthem and National Song are sung in Congress-ruled States

RAJEEV CHANDRASEKHAR
President, Kerala BJP

fore extremists has now become the Congress's permanent policy. “This is not merely an incident of stopping a song, but a mark of that dynastic arrogance under which the Congress is averse to every single thing in India that this nation takes pride in,” he said.

On the other hand, CPI

State secretary Binoy Viswam questioned the full rendition of Vande Mataram at the AICC headquarters in Delhi and in Congress-ruled States.

“A secular party can never agree to the rendition of the full version of Vande Mataram as was done at the AICC headquarters. The Congress lacks ideological clarity and is not sure of its own politics. If all their claims as the inheritors of Gandhi and Nehru's ideology are true, they should apologise for what happened,” he said.

RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 11

Will protect farmers, says Karnataka CM

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

While emphasising that it was his duty to protect farmers' interests in the Cauvery issue, Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar has said it is equally important to uphold the law.

Speaking at Bhagamandala in Kodagu district on Sunday, Mr. Shivakumar pointed out that the reservoirs in the State were still not completely full. Along with the challenge of sus-

taining the State's farmers, there was a need to uphold the law.

He said there were separate rules for water-sharing during periods of shortage and distress, and claimed that the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) had also issued the necessary directions in this regard. “If we do not follow the law, we may end up in a situation where control of the dam has to be handed over to the Central government,” Mr. Shivakumar said.

School owner lands in row over remarks

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

Controversy has erupted over the remarks by the owner of Dr. Raju Davis International School at Mala in Thrissur district of Kerala, after he reportedly told students who did not attend an Independence Day programme organised at the school to “go to Pakistan”.

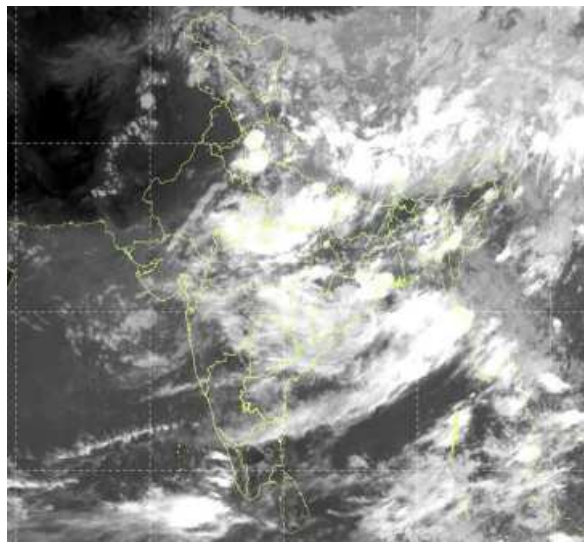
The remarks were allegedly made by school owner Raju Davis in a voice note shared in a WhatsApp

group of parents. According to the messages, students who remained absent from Independence Day celebrations were portrayed as lacking in patriotism. Mr. Davis reportedly warned that students who did not attend the programme would not be allowed to attend classes.

The issue also prompted the Students Federation of India (SFI) Mala area committee to take out a protest march to the school. Mr. Davis later expressed regret.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to Very Heavy Rainfall with isolated Extremely Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Gangetic West Bengal and Odisha. Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Assam & Meghalaya, Bihar, Haryana, Chandigarh & Delhi. Thunderstorm accompanied with Lightning very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam & Meghalaya.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		33.2	25.7	Kurnool		32.8	25.7
Ahmedabad		31.9	26.3	Lucknow		5.9	31.4
Aizawl		37	32.6	Madurai		39	25.1
Bengaluru		30.3	20.6	Mangaluru		17	29.7
Bhopal		7.6	26.8	Mumbai		7.9	31.1
Bhubaneswar		52.8	29.6	Mysuru		30	20
Chandigarh		36.2	25.6	New Delhi		34.4	27.2
Chennai		35.3	27.8	Patna		35.6	29
Coimbatore		33.3	21.6	Port Blair		31.5	27.2
Dehradun		29.4	25.1	Prayagraj		8.8	34.5
Gandhinagar		23.5	18.8	Puducherry		1	36.5
Goa		14.8	32	Pune		2.6	29
Guwahati		36.5	27.6	Raipur		27.1	—
Hubballi		00.0	00.0	Ranchi		31	23.2
Hyderabad		24.2	—	Shillong		25.5	18.5
Imphal		29.3	23.5	Shimla		0.2	27.2
Jaipur		1.3	26.8	Srinagar		—	—
Kochi		4.4	30.4	Thiruvananthapuram		31	25.3
Kohima		—	—	Tiruchirappalli		39.7	27
Kolkata		2.0	33.4	Vijayawada		7	—
Kozhikode		3.4	33.1	Visakhapatnam		32	27.9

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		44	38	35	115	102	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Brajrajnagar,
Bengaluru		25	17	119	11	31	Bhiwandi, Maharashtra
Chennai		5	7	30	12	128	recorded an overall air
Delhi		19	34	105	173	307	quality index (AQI) score
Hyderabad		6	13	11	32	63	of 334 indicating an
Kolkata		7	13	45	9	30	unhealthy level of
Lucknow		37	12	25	33	80	pollution. In contrast,
Mumbai		5	13	25	28	70	Aizawl, Mizoram recorded
Pune		5	11	63	40	57	a healthy AQI score of 14
Visakhapatnam		22	69	15	34	74	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Smt Sathya Prema (81)

W/o P. Venugopala Iyengar, passed away in Bangalore on Sunday, August 2026. The Last rites will be held at Kallahalli Crematorium at 11 am on 17.08.2026, Monday. She is survived by her husband, brother, sister, son-in-law, and two grandchildren.

BIRTH CENTENARY

CENTENARY BIRTH YEAR 43rd ANNIVERSARY

K.KANNIAH
Born : 06.07.1926 Died : 17.08.1983
- Family Members

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

98th BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE IN FOND MEMORY OF

SRI Y. SATHIAMURTHY
CHARTERED ACCOUNTANT
17.08.1928 - 16.08.2010
Family Members, Relatives & Friends.
Thirugnanam & Co
Paary & Sivasakthy Estates
Sathiamurthy Mohan VTC

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

REMEMBRANCE

DOB: 10/01/1940 DOD: 17/08/2022

Smt. RADHA
W/O. N. Thiagarajan
Fondly remembered by
Son: T. Subramanian
Daughters: C. Usha Rani, T. Shanthi
Sons-in-law, Daughter-in-law
Grand daughters, Grand sons...

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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SC / SCA / ST	Rs.250/-

Registration fees shall be paid through Debit Card / Credit Card / Net Banking / UPI through online. The registration fees may be paid through demand draft drawn in favour of “The Secretary, TNEA”, Payable at Chennai. The demand draft must be drawn on or after 17.08.2026 and to be submitted at the nearby TNEA Facilitation Center (TFC).

Commencement of Registration through Online	17.08.2026
Last Date of Registration through Online	31.08.2026

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SCHEDULE

Property being land of an extent of 4 acres 69 cents, comprised in the following Survey numbers as follows,

S.No	Survey numbers	Extent (In Acres)	Present Owners
1.	114/1	1.24	Mr. K. Balaji,
2.	114/2	0.11	Mr. G.N. Raja and
3.	114/3	0.11	Mr. E. Wilson
4.	115/1	0.31	Mr. K. Nethaji,
5.	115/2	0.27	Mr. N. Prabhu and
6.	116/1A	0.36	Mr. E. Wilson
7.	116/2	0.29	Mr. G.N. Raja and
8.	116/1B	0.33	Mr. K. Nethaji
9.	147/1	0.55	Mr. K. Balaji and
10.	147/2	1.12	Mr. G.N. Raja
Total		4.69 Acres	

Situated at **SRINIVASAPURAM Village, Sriperumbudur Taluk, Kancheepuram District** and within the Sub - Registration District off Kunrathur and Registration District of Chennai South.

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Ms. R. ANU PREETHY,
Advocate,
No. 18, VOC, Street, Nandavana Mettur,
Avadi, Chennai – 600 072.



United and free

India needs unity, not uniformity; dissent must not be seen as divisive

Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Independence Day speech, his thirteenth, was delivered within an entirely new political context, shaped by the recent student protests that led to the resignation of his Education Minister. The protests may have waned, but their underlying and lingering reasons for the unrest remain a matter of serious concern for the country. Mr. Modi sought to offer hope, inspiration and purpose on the one hand while, on the other, built a new phantom labelled ‘*dimagi* naxals’, who, he said, influenced policymaking and required purging. The speech was specifically addressed to the young citizens of the nation. Mr. Modi repeatedly stressed the need for big dreams, firm resolve and rapid execution, arguing that India could no longer think in incremental terms. He promised skill training for one crore youth over the next year to prepare India for the artificial intelligence era; free online coaching for competitive examinations to reduce the burden on families and improve access to opportunities; and renewed the government’s emphasis on innovation, quantum technology, space, robotics, data centres and other emerging sectors. Mr. Modi reiterated his commitment to self-reliance in defence production, including advanced technologies such as drones and next-generation defence systems. All Indians would naturally appreciate these promises and the statement of purpose.

Whether Mr. Modi wanted, or tried, to build a unified national approach towards these challenges and their management is doubtful. India’s progress is a continuum that should ideally have a compounding effect with each subsequent year. Comparing, in absolute terms, achievements before and after 2014, when he became Prime Minister, is neither statistically relevant nor politically prudent. The fact about India as it enters the 80th year as a free nation that fought off colonialism is that its challenges are unprecedented. It has a massive young population entering the workforce even as technology is disrupting life and work as never before. What India needs is an all-hands-on-the-deck approach, requiring a unified political will among parties and stakeholders that is unaffected by electoral contests. India also needs an indigenous understanding and philosophy of development rather than trying to mimic the techno-capitalism that is rattling advanced economies. This is a point that was underlined by the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh chief Mohan Bhagwat in his Independence Day speech. Mr. Modi clearly sees the challenges; and he also sees, unfortunately, an enemy in every critic. As he leads the country into a new year of independence, perhaps he could consider new ideas, including those from his critics, instead of amplifying divisive ones.

Not just turbulence

India’s aviation should not have to depend on chance for safety

The August 4, 2026, incident involving Air India flight AI 2379, from Phuket to Delhi, with 137 passengers and eight crew, now has two tracks. The first concerns its reclassification: the initial ‘event of turbulence’ is now a “serious incident” after inflight technical issues and a significant deviation in aircraft altitude caused injuries to more than 20 passengers and crew, quickly drawing in the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA). The subsequent probe by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau, along with France’s investigation authority, BEA, and technical representatives from Airbus, should unravel the multiple anomalies that briefly overtook the Airbus A320N – fault warnings across the hydraulic systems, elevator flight-control faults, autopilot disconnection, emergency-exit door indications and an engine anti-ice warning. Airbus’s initial data is said to support the evidence of technical errors. However, it is the second track that has received much attention: the result of the pilot-in-command’s post-flight screening for psychoactive substances.

The Tata Group-Singapore Airlines joint venture airline has been prodded into commencing the immediate and mandatory screening of its flight deck crew ‘for any substances or unprescribed medications’. But the deeply discomfiting discovery has exposed the weak link in crew screening – the greater emphasis on pre- and post-flight breathalyser checks for alcohol than on testing for psychoactive substances, which falls under the Civil Aviation Requirements (CAR) Section 5-Air Safety Series F Part V. In fact, the CAR – which applies to Air Traffic Controllers also – leans more towards random and post-flight/post-shift testing, with graded disciplinary action. With India’s air carriers expanding operations, crew citing stress-related issues, and, separately, the availability of substances for medicinal or recreational use, the regulator must ensure stringent psychoactive substance testing and operational compliance. The DGCA’s Medical Circular No. 02 of 2021, on ‘over-the-counter (OTC) drugs and self-medication’, highlights pilot cognitive/psychomotor skills impairment, drawing on the Mangaluru (2010) and Kozhikode (2020) fatal air accidents. Further, documented cases from the West reveal that even small levels of impairment can affect crew judgement, reaction time, coordination, and decision-making, the critical skills needed in the flight deck. Ensuring that fit crew are behind the controls is an aviation industry bedrock, and every Indian operator, large or growing, must uphold the highest standards. This was a lucky escape, but luck cannot be allowed to become a safety strategy.

The “One Nation, One Election (ONOE)” proposal (to enforce a uniform, synchronised timeline for national and State elections across India) represents a profound misapprehension of the structural mechanics of the parliamentary system, and poses an existential threat to the federal architecture designed by the framers of the Constitution.

To align the distinct political rhythms of dozens of individual States with the central government, in the name of national uniformity, is to prioritise administrative convenience over democratic substance. The argument for synchronisation relies heavily on a superficial calculation of financial expenditure and an overblown narrative of governance paralysis. Yet, it ignores the fundamental constitutional friction that occurs when presidential mechanics are clumsily grafted onto a parliamentary democracy.

Flexibility at democracy’s core

At the very heart of the parliamentary form of government is the principle that the executive branch derives its legitimacy directly from, and remains continuously accountable to, the legislature. Unlike a presidential system, where the executive is elected independently for a strict, unalterable calendar term, a parliamentary executive exists entirely at the pleasure of the legislative majority. A Prime Minister or a Chief Minister rules only as long as they command the confidence of the house. Consequently, the parliamentary system is inherently built around flexibility; terms are not rigidly fixed because the collapse of a governing coalition, a successful motion of no confidence, or a shifting legislative realignment must naturally trigger a democratic reset. That is why India’s elections, which ran on the same timetable from 1952 to 1967, no longer do: governments at the State and the Centre fell at different times when they lost their legislative majorities, and were elected accordingly thereafter, leading to the current situation where some State or the other is going to the elections every year.

Imposing a fixed-term electoral calendar artificially binds the legislature, completely short-circuiting this parliamentary accountability mechanism. If a government falls, forcing a fixed timeline means that the electorate is stripped of its sovereign right to choose a new government for a full five-year mandate. Instead, the system must resort to truncated midterm Assemblies elected merely to serve out the unexpired remainder of the original calendar. This introduction of variable, short-term governance undermines the stability it claims to protect, creating weak, insecure “lame-duck” administrations whose bureaucrats, police forces and political opponents will simply run down the clock rather than engage in decisive long-term policymaking.

The alternative, of resorting to President’s Rule when a State government falls, rather than



Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs and the Sahitya Akademi Award-winning author of 29 books, including ‘Our Living Constitution’

The ‘One Nation, One Election’ proposal will erode State autonomy, distort electoral mandates, and weaken democratic accountability

holding a fresh election, is even more undemocratic. This would inevitably force a domino effect of constitutional crises that severely erodes the value of a citizen’s vote. Under a synchronised system, the democratic leverage of the electorate is fundamentally distorted. A citizen voting in a midterm election to fill a two-year unexpired term is structurally handed less political bargaining power than a voter casting a ballot at the dawn of the five-year cycle. If full-term and midterm governments wield identical constitutional powers, it is a violation of democratic equity that their corresponding popular mandates carry unequal temporal weight. Furthermore, the logic of synchronisation dictates that if the national Parliament dissolves prematurely due to a fractured coalition in New Delhi, stable State legislative assemblies possessing absolute, robust majorities would be abruptly terminated by operation of law, simply to keep the national “one election” clock on course. To dissolve a functional, democratically elected State government because of a political realignment in New Delhi is a direct assault on the political sovereignty of that state’s electorate, subordinating regional democratic choices to national political dynamics.

National politics will overshadow States

This subordination exposes the deeply anti-federal undercurrents of the synchronisation agenda. India is fundamentally a union of States, a vast pluralistic landscape where regional identities, local economic contexts, and historical trajectories demand distinct political expressions. Federalism is not a mere administrative arrangement; it is a vital mechanism for cultural and political accommodation.

By combining State and national elections into a single mega-event, the distinct boundaries between localised issues and national narratives are blurred. In a synchronised ballot, national parties with vast financial apparatuses and dominant media presence naturally tend to overshadow regional players. Local grievances regarding regional infrastructure, provincial welfare, and cultural preservation risk being entirely subsumed by overarching national rhetoric or geopolitical theatre. Electorates are subtly coerced into prioritising national alignment over regional suitability, a phenomenon captured by the majoritarian push for uniform alignment under the guise of developmental efficiency. This dynamic pressures voters to instal identical parties at both the State and centre, penalising States that choose independent political paths and starving them of federal resources if they dissent from the national ruling party.

The financial justifications used to defend this centralisation of power are equally flawed. The claim that simultaneous elections will drastically cut public spending deliberately conflates the minimal, necessary administrative costs incurred

by the State with the unregulated, private campaign expenditures of political parties. The official funds spent by the Election Commission of India to manage independent cycles are a drop in the ocean for an economy of India’s scale, a small and necessary price to pay for maintaining a responsive democracy. Conversely, the vast sums of money circulated by political parties during campaigns actually function as a form of informal economic redistribution, temporarily generating widespread employment and shifting capital back down to printers, local transport networks, artisans, and working-class citizens. To restrict this economic circulation to once every five years under the banner of austerity is an argument that privileges elite fiscal preferences over the periodic economic stimuli that campaigns provide to the informal sector.

Moreover, the complaint that the continuous cycle of elections creates a perpetual state of policy paralysis due to the Model Code of Conduct is an administrative myth. The electoral code is designed strictly to prevent the ruling executive from announcing opportunistic, brand-new financial handouts or executing politically-motivated bureaucratic transfers during the immediate run-up to a vote. It does not freeze the wheels of the State, nor does it halt the execution of ongoing public works, routine governance, or essential administrative duties. The narrative of paralysis is often deployed by executives to excuse structural inefficiencies that have nothing to do with the electoral calendar. In reality, the frequency of independent State elections serves as a critical check on executive hubris, forcing political representatives to regularly return to the doorsteps of their constituents with folded hands. This continuous accountability cycle keeps political parties responsive to shifting public sentiment, whereas a single, synchronised event leaves a five-year void where representatives are essentially insulated from the popular will.

Diminishing the voter’s voice

Ultimately, the drive toward uniform elections is an attempt to transform the organic, messy vitality of a decentralised parliamentary democracy into the rigid, totalising efficiency of an authoritarian state model. It reduces the sovereign voter to a cog in an administrative machine, strips States of their distinct political timelines, and creates dangerous vacuums where insecure, short-term governments cannot effectively rule. By treating elections as an expensive administrative burden to be minimised rather than the primary lifeblood of public accountability, the ONOE model devalues the constitutional spirit of the republic. True democratic strength does not lie in forced conformity or synchronised clocks, but in the enduring resilience of a federal compact that allows its many distinct regions to live, breathe, and vote according to their own unique conditions.

India is losing West Asia, but it is not too late



Raja Karthikeya

Adjunct Fellow and Lead for West Asia Studies at the Takshashila Institution

West Asia is changing rapidly and India must act before its influence fades

India is losing West Asia, one country at a time. Even as the region undergoes a once-in-a-generation shift in its security architecture and political battle lines, it is unclear what India’s strategy is ...or whether New Delhi has one at all.

It was not supposed to be this way. Just 10 years ago, India was rapidly remaking its footprint in West Asia. In 2016, Saudi Arabia awarded India’s Prime Minister its highest civilian honour. In 2021, the I2U2 agreement was signed binding India, Israel, the United States and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) together. In 2024, Iran leased Chabahar to India. All these successes though are now memories from the past.

Pakistan’s new diplomatic moment

In the last four months, the U.S.-Israel war with Iran has escalated into a catastrophic regional conflict with Iran attacking the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries, the Saudis hitting Iraqi militias, Houthis attacking Saudi ships and Israel carrying out strikes in multiple countries. Now, the Gulf countries are rethinking the efficacy of the U.S. security umbrella. They see a threat from both Iran and Israel.

Among the Gulf countries there is a schism on how to handle this threat – through engagement (as the UAE is doing) or through deterrence (as the Saudis are contemplating).

In this context, Pakistan’s role as mediator in the U.S.-Iran conflict is gaining it reputational benefits in the region. Irrespective of Pakistan’s motives, analysts in the region see that Pakistan waded into the conflict at a time when it seemed that no one could bring U.S. President Donald Trump and the Iranians to the table despite efforts by Türkiye, Qatar and Egypt.

The latest collective defence pact in Mecca between Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan comes in this context. This pact may mean less in shaping the U.S.-Iran war as none of these

countries is likely to directly take on Iran alongside the U.S. The pact is thus aimed less at Iran and more at deterring Israel. All three countries see themselves as the next target of Israel after Iran. They thus want to pool Saudi capital, Pakistan’s military strength, and Türkiye’s technological advances.

This is a challenge for India. A future war between Israel and Pakistan will inevitably draw in India given the close partnership between Israel and India. Similarly, even greater Turkish support for Pakistan in a future conflict that Pakistan might have with India cannot be ruled out

The choices before India

What then is India’s strategy? It appears to be confident of Israel’s victory in its various battles in the region given its proximity to the U.S. But U.S. politics are changing rapidly, with both ‘Make America Great Again’ Republicans and Democratic Socialists questioning the once-unquestioned U.S. support for Israel. Can Israel then emerge triumphant alone?

India has cultivated a special relationship with the UAE given the importance of remittances from Indian expat workers in the country, the investments by the Indian elite in the UAE and the UAE’s strategic investments in India. But the UAE’s mounting differences with Saudi Arabia are a cause for concern, as are its positions against UN-recognised governments in conflicts as afar as Sudan. Can the UAE emerge unscathed in all these conflicts?

India can choose to sign military alliances with Israel and the UAE. But this would hurt what is left of India’s relationship with Iran and Saudi Arabia. India can choose to do nothing as it is doing now. And its merchant mariners may keep getting killed in the Strait of Hormuz while more Indian ships may sink in the Bab-el-Mandeb.

of *Vande Mataram* at the headquarters of the Congress party (August 16) has emerged amid the government’s emphasis on its complete rendition. Patriotism should extend beyond symbolic expressions of attachment to the nation to include a tangible commitment to the

safety, dignity and well-being of its people. Mindless violence against individuals suspected of transporting beef, or attacks on Christians at peaceful prayer meetings, are equally incompatible with the values of patriotism and constitutional democracy. The democratic ideal is not

the dominance of the majority over minorities, but a constitutional framework in which every citizen can participate with equal dignity and security. **Matthew Adukani**, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

How AI can be optimised for better healthcare

Modern medicine has built an extraordinary depth of knowledge. However, how much of that knowledge can reach the patient who needs it now? The answer has traditionally depended on the number and distribution of trained clinicians, the institutions in which they work, and the systems that connect them to patients. All three are difficult to expand quickly. For India, which is still expanding its healthcare capacity while its disease burden becomes more complex, the question of how far health expertise can reach is particularly consequential.

Here, Artificial Intelligence (AI) introduces a new dimension. It offers a way of taking the accumulated knowledge and making more of it available at the point of care. The change is visible across major health systems. In January 2025, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) said it had authorised more than 1,000 AI-enabled medical devices. These include tools used in radiology, cardiology, and other areas of diagnosis. In the U.K., the NHS issued a guidance in April 2025 for the use of AI-enabled ambient scribing. By January 2026, the country was developing a national programme to support wider adoption, with early evidence suggesting that the technology could give doctors up to a quarter more time with their patients.

These examples point to a wider change. AI is moving out of innovation teams and into consultations, diagnostic workflows, and hospital operations. The real work now lies in making it dependable enough for routine use.

The economic benefits
India has its own set of challenges. Specialist care remains concentrated in larger cities, while chronic conditions require patients to be monitored over many years. Hospitals are also managing rising volumes without being able to increase clinical



Suneeta Reddy

Managing Director,
Apollo Hospitals
Enterprise Ltd.

A January 2026 McKinsey analysis estimated that applying AI across healthcare revenue-cycle operations could reduce the cost to collect by 30% to 60%

capacity at the same pace. An AI tool that helps prioritise a radiology scan, alerts a care team to a deteriorating patient or supports a physician handling a complex case in a smaller city can make existing capacity work more efficiently.

The country has already built much of the digital foundation required for this shift. By May 2026, more than 100 crore health records had been linked to the Ayushman Bharat Health Accounts, twice the number recorded in February 2025. A July 2026 government update reported that the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (ABDM) Scan and Share service had reduced outpatient registration waits at participating hospitals from around an hour to between two and five minutes. These improvements did not require a dramatic reinvention. It came from removing friction from a familiar hospital process. AI can extend the same principle to appointment scheduling, clinical documentation, claims, inventory planning, and discharge management. Each task takes time away from care if handled poorly.

Additionally, the financial benefits from using AI is becoming harder for healthcare providers to ignore. A January 2026 McKinsey analysis estimated that applying AI across healthcare revenue-cycle operations could reduce the cost to collect by 30% to 60%. For hospitals, these gains can free resources for clinical teams, equipment and capacity. They can also reduce administrative work that contributes to staff fatigue.

There is yet another part related to the business side that receives less attention. AI can help providers offer services that were previously difficult to deliver at scale. Remote monitoring can extend care beyond discharge. Risk-based preventive programmes can identify people who need attention before symptoms become severe. Virtual specialist support can connect smaller hospitals with expertise located elsewhere. Diagnostics can

be taken closer to communities, while hospitals maintain an ongoing relationship with patients managing diabetes, cardiac disease or cancer.

Judicious use
These models create revenue, but their value does not come from selling more technology. It comes from reaching patients earlier and avoiding preventable deterioration. This is also where restraint matters. A system that performs well in one hospital or population may not work equally well across India's States, disease patterns, and care settings. Clinical validation, representative data, and human oversight also need to be seriously considered. The FDA's September 2025 call for better methods to evaluate AI-enabled devices in real-world settings reflects a concern that every health system will have to confront. The tools' performance at launch does not guarantee performance over time.

Healthcare does not need AI everywhere. It needs it where delays can be reduced, clinicians can make better-informed decisions, and more patients can receive appropriate care. As India marks another year of Independence, there is a larger dimension to this conversation. The economic strength of a nation ultimately rests on the capabilities of its people. Healthcare therefore belongs within the architecture of economic development. India has built considerable physical and digital infrastructure over the decades; the next phase of development will depend increasingly on the health, longevity and productivity of its population. AI can contribute by making expertise widely available and by shifting healthcare towards earlier detection and continuous management.

The economic return on AI in healthcare will be measured not by the number of systems deployed, but by the number of lives touched and its impact on human life and happiness.

Andhra's urban transformation

The State's municipal department is trying to build a sustainable urban model

STATE OF PLAY

V. Raghavendra

The Municipal Administration and Urban Development (MA&UD) Department of Andhra Pradesh is caught in the time warp of archaic administrative measures. But now it seems the light has dawned as it tries to catch up with the times.

A top official of the department, at the recent Green Andhra Summit organised by the Indian Green Building Council, noted in disbelief that one of the most laughable things about urban local bodies was its imposition of a 'tree guard fee'. The audience went into a fit of giggles as the official continued to say that about 45 different types of charges are being collected by the MA&UD Department. He stated that he has since sought to make systemic changes with a new sense of urgency in order to achieve sustainable development.

An overhaul
The government is streamlining a whole lot of procedures and doing away with redundant ones in keeping with the Swarna Andhra 2047 Vision.

A significant step towards transforming cities and towns into cleaner urban agglomerations is a mandate to apartment complexes, if the waste generated per day exceeds 100 kilos, to set up their own in-situ solid waste management units. This has not yet been made formally mandatory, but it is a welcome move as the government intends to rid cities and towns of waste.

To complement this move, the department contemplated giving incentives for using treated wastewater, like it is done in some advanced coun-



tries across industrial, commercial, and drinking purposes. The Reuse of Treated Used Water Policy, 2026 has been approved by the government to boost long-term water security, reduce freshwater dependence, and promote a circular water economy.

Additionally, the existing model of developing slums is being reworked to achieve the twin objectives of improving the quality of life for the slum dwellers and making cities look beautiful. Towards this, the Greater Visakhapatnam Municipal Corporation is embarking on the redevelopment of a slum on the DBFT (Design, Build, Finance and Transfer) basis under the Visakhapatnam Economic Region Program through suitable amendments to the Andhra Pradesh Building Rules of 2017. It involves the construction of a high-rise building which should accommodate 177 housing units. This is a first-of-its-kind project taken up anywhere in the State as a result of the slew of relaxations made in the Floor Space Index (FSI) norms in order to make projects viable for developers in small slum areas.

A green economy
The MA&UD Department has also laid greater thrust on green buildings by encouraging the use of green materials at the design stage itself as well as for necessary modifications in existing buildings; va-

rious incentives are also being planned to accelerate this adoption such as giving discounts in development charges, irrespective of the types of use (residential or commercial). The focus on green buildings is in tune with the growing need to reduce the carbon footprint of the construction sector, and in the process facilitate the unobstructed transmission of natural light and free flow of air, which makes the buildings energy-efficient and thereby economically viable.

Keeping in view the multiple benefits of green buildings, the government is extending the initiative to ordinary houses, schools, hospitals, and commercial establishments like never before. It has also stipulated hefty penalties in case of violations.

These things apart, the government has prioritised the optimisation of land use (utilising vacant private land for public spaces) and transit-oriented development to incentivise transit corridors and stops. The MA&UD has already eased the zoning regulations and reduced the number of zones from 15 to 10 for the sake of flexibility in urban development.

The whole idea, as per the MA&UD official, is to make the city grow rapidly and be adaptive, like it happened with London and Paris among other great global cities.

A decisive shift is thus underway towards deep-tech governance, fiscal self-reliance, and environmentally resilient urban living, keeping in line with the theme 'build faster and better and grow green'. This can already be seen in Amaravati, the emerging greenfield capital city of Andhra Pradesh.

raghavendra.v@thehindu.co.in

Girls conditioned from childhood to take up domestic burden

The time women spend on housework begins to rise around the age of 10 and reaches a peak of nearly 460 minutes a day around age 30

DATA POINT

Tanu M. Goyal
Mohd. Tahoore
Shravani Prakash

In a recent interaction with women aspiring to become entrepreneurs in rural Haryana, it was found that other than social and cultural norms, the biggest practical problem constraining the women's ability to do more paid work was that a large share of their time was tied up in cooking and completing household chores. Strikingly, their daughters, rather than their sons, were already sharing this burden by helping them in the kitchen and other chores. The next generation, it seemed, is already learning to reproduce the gender gap in invisible, unpaid work.

India's Time Use Survey (2025) highlights that the division of labour that emerges in adulthood begins much earlier, through childhood conditioning. What starts in childhood widens with age, reaching its peak in the prime working years (**Chart 1**).

The time women spend on housework begins to rise around the age of 10 and continues through the late teens and twenties, reaching a peak of nearly 460 minutes (7.5 hours +) a day around age 30. The male curve, however, never crosses 65 minutes at any age between six and 75. Adolescence, in this sense, is not separate from adulthood; it is when the adult pattern begins to take shape (**Chart 1**). Data shows that at age six, Indian boys and girls spend almost the same amount of time on domestic and care work at about five minutes a day (**Chart 2**). Their trajectories remain relatively close through early childhood. Thereafter, however, they diverge sharply.

Around age 10, the girls' curve begins to pull away. Girls spend about 15 minutes a day on domestic and care work at age 10, 75 minutes at 15, and around 130 mi-

nutes by age 17. Boys, meanwhile, move from roughly five minutes at age six to only about 17 minutes by the end of childhood. The result is a dramatic widening of the gender gap. The girl-to-boy ratio in unpaid work rises from 1.6 among children aged 6-9, to 4.5 among those aged 10-14, and to 7.5 among adolescents aged 15-17.

Little control over time
The cost is leisure. Between ages six and 17, girls' housework rises by roughly 124 minutes a day, while their leisure time falls by around 115 minutes. For boys, the decline in leisure is much smaller but the time they spend on housework changes relatively little.

This matters because the cost of girls' domestic work is often framed primarily as a trade-off with schooling and education. But data shows that girls, in fact, are spending slightly more time on learning than boys at most ages. They, therefore, remain in school but still pay a substantial price in leisure time that could be spent on sport, friendships, rest, exploration and simply having discretionary control over their own time. These are not economically irrelevant activities. They are part of how children build confidence, social networks, physical capability and even a sense of agency, all of which influence their ability to build career trajectories later in life (**Chart 2**).

Cooking lies at the centre of this divergence (**Chart 3**). Among adolescents aged 15-17 years, 42.4% of girls report cooking, compared with only 2.9% of boys. Girls in this age group spend close to an hour cooking, while boys spend just two minutes. Cleaning and laundry also become increasingly gendered, with wide gaps in both participation and time spent. The only tasks where adolescent boys match or exceed girls are farm work and shopping; activities that are more outward-facing (the field and market), rather than inward-facing into the kitchen.

Between childhood and adulthood, therefore, girls are being trained for the household while boys are being trained for the world outside. This helps explain why childhood conditioning can later appear as an "efficient" gendered allocation of household work.

One of the clearest manifestations of these gendered expectations is women's absence from the labour force. In the 2025 PLFS, childcare and domestic responsibilities were the single most-cited reason women gave for staying out of the labour force, reported by 52.5% of urban women and 40% of rural women, compared with less than 1% of men.

Most policy interventions address women's unpaid work in adulthood through childcare, community kitchens, safe mobility infrastructure, flexible work and social protection, among others. But the Time Use Survey suggests that policy must also start much earlier, by addressing the unequal assignment of domestic work between boys and girls.

The objective is not to remove domestic work from children's lives, but to remove its gender assignment. Schools can help by giving every child, boy or girl, equal opportunities to learn practical life skills, from cooking and home management to stitching, carpentry and financial management.

India has invested heavily in keeping girls in school and improving their educational outcomes, but equal attention must be paid to what happens to their time outside school. Otherwise, by the time young women enter the labour market, years of gendered conditioning and unpaid work may already have narrowed their choices. If we want a different workforce tomorrow, we may need to start by giving boys and girls a different childhood today.

Authors work at the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER). Views expressed are personal

Disproportionate burden

The data for the charts were sourced from India's Time Use Survey (2025) and the Ministry of Statistics and Program Implementation (MoSPI)

CHART 1: Time spent on housework (unpaid domestic and caregiving services)

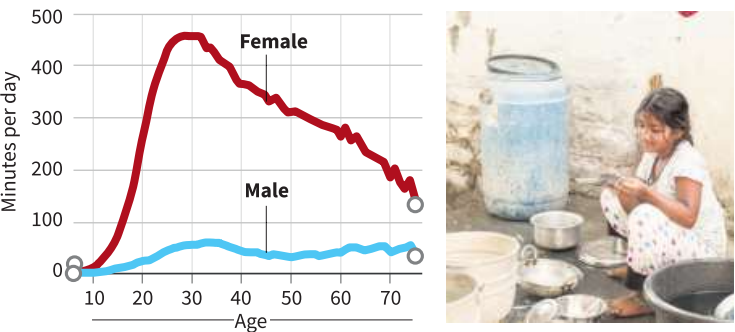


CHART 2: Time spent by children on domestic work, leisure and learning

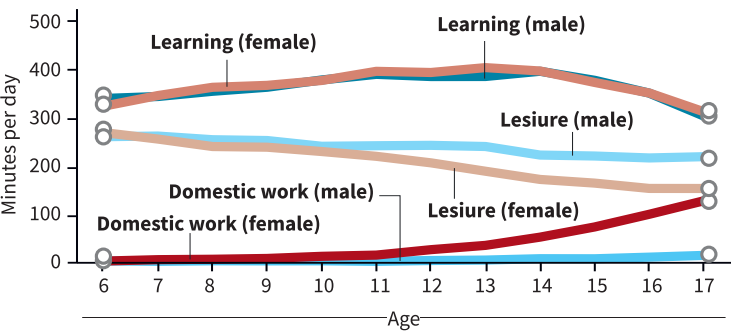
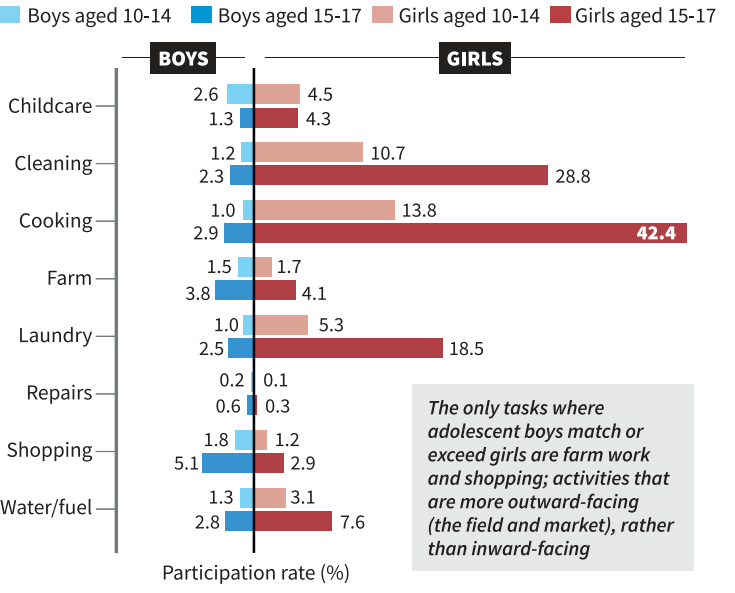


CHART 3: The share (participation rate) of girls and boys who engage in different types of housework



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO AUGUST 17, 1976

Water supplies dry up in U.K.

London, August 16: The possibility that Britain, an island normally drenched by Atlantic rains, may have to import drinking water is now being seriously studied by planners, according to informed sources.

With no sign of a let-up in the country's worst drought since 1727 when records started officials recognise that such drastic action as importing water by ship from Scandinavia and distributing it by tanker lorries may become necessary.

Water supplies are rapidly drying up and a million homes in South Wales already have water cut off at night. From next month, people in parts of Western England will have to queue at Stand-pipes for supplies.

Strict rationing starts in the Channel Island of Jersey to-day and has been in force in neighbouring Guernsey island since a state of emergency was declared in June. Without such measures water would run out in six weeks.

After revelling an untypically dry and glorious summer, Britons are now waking up to the prospect that if the rains stay away through the autumn they could be in for a winter of hardship with food and industrial production hit.

All 10 water authorities in England and Wales have promptly told the Government that they will be applying to use powers made available under the Drought Act. Three authorities covering North-East, South, West and the whole of Wales are demanding the right to cut off water to homes whenever they wish.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO AUGUST 17, 1926

Manchester cotton trade

London, August 16: The Federation of Master Cotton Spinners Association has inaugurated a scheme for the protection of American Spinning Section of the trade from undercost selling. "Basic prices" which are in effect minimum prices, are fixed for a standard quality of American cotton and beams. Salesmen of the Manchester Exchange representing firms producing these yarns have been instructed to quote prices coinciding with the Federation's list. The elimination of cheap sellers seems only a matter of time if the Federation members stand together. The Federation and Non-Federation concerns have promised loyal support.

CM
YK

SIR helped Bihar achieve record poll turnout: CEC

The Hindu Bureau
PATNA

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday said that the ‘successful’ conduct of Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls in Bihar last year helped to increase the voter turnout in the State Assembly election that followed.

Mr. Kumar landed in Patna on Sunday for a two-day visit to Bihar. Thanking the voters of Bihar, at a press conference at the airport, the CEC said he had come to pay his respects to the sacred land of Bihar.

He asserted that SIR was the most successful nationwide initiative for the purification of electoral rolls and it originated in Bihar. The voter turnout during the last Assembly election was the highest recorded since Independence.

The CEC said the SIR exercise resulted in around 70 lakh names being removed from the electoral rolls. “The revision was followed by the Assembly elections, which recorded a significant rise in voter turnout,” he said.

Mr. Kumar is scheduled to visit Vaishali, Madhubani and Sitamarhi. On Monday, he will interact with around 500 Booth Level Officers in Rajgir.

Shah seeks Congress apology over Vande Mataram row

Union Home Minister, Bengal CM accuse the Opposition party of ‘disrespecting’ the National Song; Bankim Chandra’s descendant writes letter to Sonia Gandhi; Congress denies any wrongdoing

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR/KOLKATA

Escalating the controversy over the National Song’s rendition at the Congress headquarters on Independence Day, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday demanded an apology from the Opposition party for “disrespecting” *Vande Mataram*.

Mr. Shah accused Congress leader Sonia Gandhi of asking for the National Song to be stopped midway during the Independence Day event. The Congress has denied the charge, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full, six-stanza version of the song. The party said Ms. Gandhi was only asking for a chair for Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge, who was standing for quite some time.

Addressing a public meeting at Nimbahera in Rajasthan’s Chittorgarh district, Mr. Shah said, “The people of the country will never forgive this sin you have committed. If Congress members have any shame left, they should fold their hands and apologise to the people,” Mr. Shah said.



Amit Shah waves the Tiranga at a public meet in Alwar, Rajasthan, on Sunday. Union Minister Bhupender Yadav is also seen. PTI

“Thousands of people went to the gallows, faced bullets, endured lathi charge and were jailed while chanting *Vande Mataram*. But the Congress has forgotten it for a vote bank,” he said.

‘Sacred symbol’

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MLA Sumitra Chatterjee – a descendant of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, who wrote the lyrics of the song 150 years ago – demanded an apology from Ms. Gandhi.

Mr. Chatterjee, who represents the Naihati constituency in the West Bengal Assembly, shot off a letter to Ms. Gandhi dated August 15, saying that *Vande Mataram* was “not the ancestral property” of any single political party. “It is part of the nation’s collective memory, the eternal legacy of Bankim Chandra, and a sacred national symbol earned through the blood and sacrifice of millions of martyrs,” he wrote.

“As a descendant of Rishi Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay’s family, I urge you – in humble yet

Complaint lodged with Delhi Police

NEW DELHI

An inquiry has been initiated after two lawyers asked the Delhi Police to register a first information report (FIR) against Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi under the provisions of a new law seeking to punish insults to the National Song. The complaint filed at the Indraprastha Estate Police Station here sought probe into the “intentional obstruction” caused during the rendition of the song at AICC headquarters.

firm terms – to engage in introspection and offer an unconditional apology,” Mr. Chatterjee added.

Mr. Adhikari also criticised Ms. Gandhi, claiming that her “objection” to singing the full version of *Vande Mataram* was an “insult” to the song writer’s nationalism. “I condemn Congress Parliamentary Party chairpersons Sonia Gandhi’s objection to *Vande Mataram*. This is an insult to nationalism, patriotism and to the creator of *Vande Mataram*,” Mr. Adhikari said at the State Secretariat in Kolkata.

Home Minister is trying to divert attention from more pressing issues: Congress

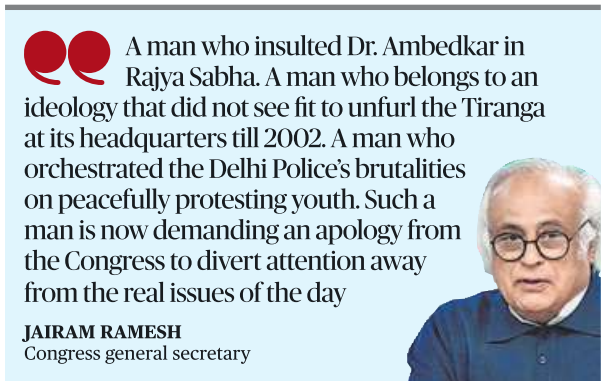
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Sunday strongly rebutted Union Home Minister Amit Shah’s charge that the party had insulted the National Song *Vande Mataram*, asserting that it has always respected the song and accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of trying to manufacture a political controversy.

The fresh exchange came a day after a row erupted during Independence Day celebrations at the All India Congress Committee (AICC) headquarters in New Delhi on Saturday, where Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi was seen gesturing towards party president Mallikarjun Kharge while *Vande Mataram* was being sung.

Addressing a public gathering in Chittorgarh, Rajasthan, Mr. Shah accused the Congress of disrespecting the National Song and demanded an apology from the party. Referring to a footage from the Independence Day function, he alleged that Ms. Gandhi had asked the Congress president to stop the song midway.

“We all saw it on televi-



JAIRAM RAMESH
Congress general secretary

sion,” Mr. Shah said, adding that Ms. Gandhi should apologise to the people of the country.

Responding to the charge, Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal dismissed the allegation and maintained that the party’s commitment to *Vande Mataram* was beyond doubt.

Speaking to presspersons in Kollam, Kerala, Mr. Venugopal said the controversy had arisen out of a misunderstanding. “For the BJP, everything is political. For us, it is emotional. What happened at the AICC headquarters was a communication issue. We are people who respect *Vande Mataram*. The Congress has a clear stand on *Vande Mataram*, and you will understand it in due course,” he said.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh also launched a sharp attack on the Home Minister, accusing him of attempting to divert attention from more pressing issues.

In a post on social media platform X, Mr. Ramesh said: “A man who insulted Dr. Ambedkar on the floor of the Rajya Sabha on December 17, 2024. A man who belongs to an ideology that did not see fit to unfurl the Tiranga at its headquarters till January 2002. A man who orchestrated the Delhi Police’s brutalities on peacefully protesting youth. Such a man is now demanding an apology from the Congress to divert attention away from the real issues of the day and away from the colossal failures of his and his Sahib’s.”

Congress steps up student outreach campaign on exams and joblessness

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

In 2014, the Bihar Staff Selection Commission notified vacancies for various positions, including forest guards, assistant sub-inspectors, lower division clerks and stenographers. The examination was conducted in 2018, and the results were declared only in 2022, eight years after the posts were first advertised.

Rakesh Chandan (name changed), 32, from Patna, was among those who took the examination. By the time the results were announced, he said, many successful candidates had become ineligible to join because they had crossed the age limit prescribed for recruitment.

In 2012, Prashant Pandey (name changed), 37, from a small town near Dehradun in Uttarakhand, cleared the written examination for the post of sub-inspector in the Indo-Tibe-



All ears: Rahul Gandhi listening to grievances from students during a public meeting in Prayagraj, ANI

tan Border Police. He was found to be 2kg short of the required weight and was asked to undergo another medical examination. Three months later, he was informed that the recruitment process had been indefinitely postponed.

The common thread linking these two stories, separated by more than 1,000 km, is the Congress party and its efforts to mobilise the growing frustration among students and

job aspirants. Since June, the party has been reaching out to aspirants preparing for public recruitment and educational examinations, including NEET, as part of its “*Chhatron Ki Goonj*” initiative.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi has addressed three public meetings in Kota, Dehradun and Prayagraj. On Sunday, he announced another event in Pune on August 22 that will

focus exclusively on women aspirants.

So far, 16 focus group discussions have been held in Delhi, Patna and Dehradun. The decision to focus on women aspirants, a party leader said, emerged from these discussions, during which female candidates spoke about the greater odds they face, including a narrow window to pursue their careers owing to the “looming deadline” to get married.

A senior party leader said each focus group was curated to bring together participants from different caste, class, gender and geographical backgrounds.

The discussions follow a familiar pattern. Participants speak of inheriting aspirations for government jobs from their families, the years spent preparing for exams, the money invested in coaching centres, and the repeated setbacks caused by paper leaks and delayed recruitments.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A political row erupted over Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s reference to “*dimagi* [intellectual] Naxals” in his Independence Day address, with Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju clarifying on Sunday that the remark was not aimed at Opposition leaders.

In a post on X, Mr. Rijiju said Mr. Modi’s comments were directed only at those who “support Maoists and reject the Indian Constitution”, “stand with separatists and support Article 370 [special status for J&K], and those who “want to cut the chicken neck to separate the north-east from India”.

Mr. Modi didn’t say Opposition leaders are *dimagi* Naxals, Mr. Rijiju said.

The clarification came after senior Congress leader and former Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram



Union Minister Kiren Rijiju in a post on X on Sunday listed out the categories the Prime Minister purportedly referred to. SANSAD TV

posted on X: “I am proud to be a *dimagi* Naxal”.

Addressing the nation on the 80th Independence Day on Saturday, Mr. Modi alleged that *dimagi* Naxals had entrenched themselves in the system and continued to influence society through policy manipulation. He said that while “armed Naxals may have gone”, “*dimagi* Naxals are lurking around”, and called for “identifying and isolating” them.

Congress Rajya Sabha member Pawan Khara mocked Mr. Rijiju’s post. “Brother Kiren Rijiju, get your counting right first, then we’ll answer. After 1 and 2 comes 3, not 4,” Mr. Khara wrote on X.

Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh backed Mr. Khara, saying, “Entire Political Science’s *kamaal* [magic],” in an apparent reference to Mr. Modi’s educational qualification, listed in one of his

affidavits as “entire political science”.

‘No surprise’
The BJP leaders, meanwhile, stepped up their attack on Mr. Chidambaram.

BJP MP Nishikant Dubey shared an old video of the former Home Minister in which he purportedly argued against acquiring and inducting nuclear weapons without a wider debate in Parliament and the country.

“Looking at the state of the world today, tell me if this statement by Mr. Chidambaram, a leader of Sonia Gandhi-led Congress, is the statement of a ‘*dimagi* Naxal’ or not?” Mr. Dubey said.

BJP general secretary B.L. Santhosh said there was “no surprise” in Mr. Chidambaram’s stance, and alleged that he had been the “PMC (Project Management Consultant) of the saffron terrorism project of the UPA”.

BJP govt. in U.P. planning to provide ‘stolen money’ to women as allowance: SP

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav took a jab at the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh on Sunday over allegations of donations embezzlement at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. He called on people to vote out the ruling party in the Assembly election scheduled for early next year.

Mr. Yadav shared a three-minute AI-generated video on X that showed people rejecting money offered to them because it was stolen.

Mr. Yadav was responding to reports that the State government was likely to announce a grant of ₹20,000 for women in Uttar Pradesh.

Earlier, Mr. Yadav said on X: “Another BJP *jumla*: a grant of

₹20,000 to U.P.’s women. The BJP has nothing left to win elections except money. Women in Uttar Pradesh say that in other States where they won elections by granting money to women, they are either refusing to pay up or demanding its return. And for those women who are unable to return it, the BJP is taking action against them through the police and courts. A closer look at this issue makes it apparent that the BJP government could have provided ₹50,000 annually, but it didn’t. The CM [Yogi Adityanath] has tricked everyone by spending thousands of crores of rupees meant for the rights of women in U.P. on his own publicity.”

The SP president countered with his own promise of an annual allowance of ₹40,000 to women. This amount will be increased every year, he said.

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PUNGRAIN, on behalf of all State Procuring Agencies (Pungrain, PSWC, Punsup and Markfed), invites online tenders through e-Procurement Portal for the purchase of LDPE Black Tarpsulins for safe storage of paddy to be procured during KMS 2026-27 in the State of Punjab under two Bid system.

For details log onto: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> or <http://foodsupp.pb.gov.in>

Bid submission period: From 10:00 AM on 17.08.2026 till 10:00 AM on 08.09.2026.

Pre-bid Conference: On 20.08.2026 at 11:00 AM in the Committee room, Anaj Bhawan, Sector 39-C, Chandigarh.

Technical Bid Opening: At 10:30 AM on 08.09.2026.

Note:

- PUNGRAIN reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason thereof.
- Any corrigendum/ addendum to the tender shall be uploaded on the above portal/ website only.

1026/12/2026-27/14312 Managing Director, Pungrain

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ई-निविदा आमंत्रित करते हुए संक्षिप्त सूचना / BRIEF NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER दिनांक / Date : 14.08.2026

भारत के राष्ट्रपति की ओर से निम्नलिखित कार्य के लिए ई-टेंडरिंग द्वारा अर्जितलाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं।
On behalf of the President of India, online tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following works.

1. आरपीसी, वीएसएससी, तुंबा के भवन सं. आर-123 में 5 अक्ष सामग्री मिल नुसारन के लिए नौच का निर्माण (सिखल कार्य) / Construction of foundation for 5 axis CNC mill turn machine in building no. R-123 at RPP, VSSC, Thumba (Civil works)
NIT No. VSSC/CMG/C01/13/2026-27 Dt. 14.08.2026 (पी.ए.सी./P.A.C. ₹.28.97 लाख/Lakhs)
डाउनलोड करने की अवधि / Period for downloading: दिनांक 15.08.2026, 10.00 बजे /hrs. से 10 दिनांक 29.08.2026, 23.00 बजे /hrs

ई-निविदा की अवधि बढ़ाना / EXTENSION OF E-TENDER

2. नौआरसी, वीएसएससी, तुंबा में सबक का पुनःसुलक्षण कार्य / Road resurfacing works at VRC, VSSC, Thumba, NIT No. VSSC/CMG/C01/11/2026-27 Dt. 24.07.2026 (पी.ए.सी./P.A.C. ₹.465.50 लाख/Lakhs)
डाउनलोड करने की अवधि / Period for downloading: दिनांक 29.08.2026 को 23:00 बजे तक बढ़ाए गए / Extended upto 23:00 hrs. on 29.08.2026

इच्छुक निविदाकार व्यौरों के लिए www.tenderwizad.in/isro या www.isro.gov.in देखें / Interested tenderers may visit www.tenderwizad.in/isro or www.isro.gov.in for details.

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Sl. No	Online Tender no with qty/ Document Cost	Sale Period	Pre bid	Submission	Opening	
1	E1567/MOB/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - AAC Software with Tablet (174) & SmartPhone (8800) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 16.09.2026	01.09.2026 12.00 Noon	17.09.2026 11.00 AM	17.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
2	E1568/EYE/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Reflective Folding Stick (3070) & Modular Reflective Folding Stick (270) – Rs.2.290/-	20.08.2026 to 07.09.2026	27.08.2026 11.00 AM	08.09.2026 11.00 AM	08.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
3	E1569/EYE/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Modular Reading Device (114) & Electronic Braille Reader (90) – Rs.5.725/-	20.08.2026 to 07.09.2026	27.08.2026 11.30 AM	08.09.2026 11.00 AM	08.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
4	E1570/WC/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Wheel Chair (6286) – Rs.5.725/-	20.08.2026 to 07.09.2026	27.08.2026 12.00 Noon	08.09.2026 11.00 AM	08.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
5	E1571/ENT/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Hearing Aid (9500) – Rs.5.725/-	20.08.2026 to 07.09.2026	27.08.2026 12.30 PM	08.09.2026 11.00 AM	08.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
6	E1572/SW/MC/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Sewing Machine (8150) – Rs.5.725/-	21.08.2026 to 08.09.2026	28.08.2026 11.00 AM	09.09.2026 11.00 AM	09.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
7	E1573/T-CYCLE/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Tri-Cycle (694) – Rs.5.725/-	21.08.2026 to 08.09.2026	28.08.2026 11.30 AM	09.09.2026 11.00 AM	09.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
8	E1574/BWC/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Battery operated Wheel Chair (1642) – Rs.5.725/-	21.08.2026 to 08.09.2026	28.08.2026 12.00 Noon	09.09.2026 11.00 AM	09.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
For details visit www.tntenders.gov.in and TNMSC website www.tnmsc.tn.gov.in DIPR/ 2585 /TENDER/2026						
GENERAL MANGER (EQUIPMENT)						

TAMILNADU MEDICAL SERVICES CORPORATION LTD. No.417, Pantheon Road, Egmore, Chennai-600008. Phone: 28191890/28190259; Fax: 044 -28190636; Mail: equipment.tnmsc@tn.gov.in						
Sl. No	Online Tender no with qty/ Document Cost	Sale Period	Pre bid	Submission	Opening	
1	E1560/VEH/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Retrofitted Patrol Scooter (15100) & Specially Designed Retrofitted Patrol Scooter for Spinal Cord Injured (350) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 16.09.2026	01.09.2026 11.00 AM	17.09.2026 11.00 AM	17.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
2	E1561/CRU/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Auxiliary Crutches (2420), Elbow Crutches (2122) & Walking Device (418) – Rs.3.435/-	18.08.2026 to 01.09.2026	24.08.2026 11.00 AM	02.09.2026 11.00 AM	02.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
3	E1562/FR/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Standing Frame Size (502) & Corner Seat Size (476) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 02.09.2026	25.08.2026 11.00 AM	03.09.2026 11.00 AM	03.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
4	E1563/P-CAL/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Plastic Caliper (436) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 02.09.2026	25.08.2026 11.30 AM	03.09.2026 11.00 AM	03.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
5	E1564/M-CAL/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Metal Caliper (40) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 02.09.2026	25.08.2026 12.00 Noon	03.09.2026 11.00 AM	03.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
6	E1565/A-LIMB/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Various type of Artificial Limb (388) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 02.09.2026	25.08.2026 12.30 PM	03.09.2026 11.00 AM	03.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
7	E1566/EYE/CWDA/RC/TNMSC/ENG/2026, dt:14.08.2026 - Magnifier (156), Goggles (3020) & Braille Watches (2160) – Rs.5.725/-	18.08.2026 to 02.09.2026	25.08.2026 01.00 PM	03.09.2026 11.00 AM	03.09.2026 12.00 Noon	
For details visit www.tntenders.gov.in and TNMSC website www.tnmsc.tn.gov.in DIPR/ 2585 /TENDER/2026						
GENERAL MANGER (EQUIPMENT)						

INBRIEF



One of Assam’s sharpest wildlife guard dogs retires

One of Assam’s sharpest wildlife guard dogs retired from service on India’s 80th Independence Day. Leon, a Belgian Malinois, tracked wildlife crime suspects, assisted in anti-poaching operations, and guarded some of Assam’s most precious fauna. The highlight of his career was guiding Assam Forest Department and police personnel to a rhino poacher after following the suspect’s scent trail for nearly 20 km across several forest camps and security checkpoints during the 2019 floods. On Saturday, the Forest Department and police retired Leon with official honours in recognition of his service since joining field duty in November 2018.

Navy sailor, wife, 2 children found dead in Mumbai home

The bodies of an Indian Navy sailor, his wife, and their two children were recovered from their official accommodation at Navy Nagar in Mumbai’s Colaba on Saturday, prompting the police and naval authorities to launch separate investigations. Naval security personnel and the Mumbai Police were alerted after the family did not respond to telephone calls. A subsequent check of the quarters resulted in the recovery of the bodies. A statement issued by the Navy said the police have registered a case and initiated an inquiry. The residence has been sealed, and a forensic team has examined the premises. “We are providing all assistance to the civil police in their investigation,” a Navy representative said.

2 staff injured as passenger’s gun goes off at airport in U.P.

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Two workers involved in baggage screening were injured at the Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport in Varanasi on Sunday when a passenger’s pistol went off accidentally.

Air India Express passenger Kamlesh Rai, a resident of Azamgarh district in Uttar Pradesh, declared a licensed firearm (7.62 mm pistol with 21 live cartridges) at the check-in counter at the airport as required under the prescribed procedure.

During the inspection of the weapon, it accidentally went off, with a bullet hitting Rohit Raj and Suman Kumari, who were involved in in-line baggage screening.

Ms. Kumari was injured in her leg and Mr. Raj in his thumb. Both were admitted to hospital.

“Today, 16.08.2026, at about 0930 hrs, a passenger travelling with his wife on flight IX-1810 to Mumbai declared weapons [to be carried] on board the flight. During the weapons check, a round went off..., injuring two AAICLAS screeners. Local police have been informed, and an investigation is under way,” read a statement by Varanasi Airport Authority.

Panel flags absence of policy to shut mines in Meghalaya

High Court-constituted committee questions the State’s lethargy in adopting the policy to close all rat-hole mine openings; the State had been advised years ago to seal illegally operated mines

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

A panel constituted by the High Court of Meghalaya has flagged the State’s lethargy in adopting a policy to close all rat-hole mine openings and fence those that pose danger to humans and livestock.

In its 39th Interim Report submitted to the court last week, the one-man Justice (retired) B.P. Katakey Committee underlined the absence of a comprehensive action plan, the non-adoption of a mine closure policy, and serious gaps in the scrutiny of coal-based industries, specifically coke oven plants that thrive on coal.

The panel noted that the Meghalaya government heeded some of its recommendations, but has largely ignored the mine closure policy. The State had been advised years ago to seal abandoned and active but illegally operated mines that have been death traps for humans, specifically children, and livestock.

There are also instances of murderers using these pits to dump the bodies of their victims.



Rescue operations under way at an illegal rat-hole coal mine blast site to rescue trapped mine workers, in East Jaintia Hills. FILE PHOTO

The Katakey panel says the Central Mine Planning and Design Institute Limited prepared detailed project reports (DPRs) for two pilot restoration projects – one at Sutnga in East Jaintia Hills (₹63 lakh) and the other at Arenggtim in South Garo Hills district (₹92.78 lakh).

Proposals pending

Both proposals have been pending before the National Green Tribunal-constituted Oversight Committee, a hybrid Centre-State body comprising 12

members.

The Katakey panel observed that the DPRs focus on land restoration, but lack adequate protective measures, including fencing, until works are completed. It insisted that immediate steps are essential to prevent further loss of human and animal lives, noting that thousands of open coal mines exist across Meghalaya.

According to the Jaintia Coal Mines Owners and Dealers’ Association, there are about 60,000 mines spread across 360 villages

Sumit Sarkar brought ordinary people, their experiences into history books

TRIBUTE

Janaki Nair

I did not have the good fortune of being taught by Sumit Sarkar. But like every (conscientious) modern Indian historian, I have indeed been ‘taught’ by him. His classic, *Modern India*, modestly described as a ‘textbook’, is perhaps the most well-thumbed of my many books. Here, along with colonial masters and nationalist leaders, peasants, workers, and ordinary people sprang from its pages.

This was no simple inclusion: it was a conceptual break, altering our understanding of Indian history in profound ways, acknowledging the lives and actions of millions, even their failures, as the true basis on which to understand our past. But political leaders, their actions, and the periodisations familiar to students of histo-

ry could not be dispensed with altogether. Therefore, the book, despite its emphasis on the novel breakthroughs of a ‘history from below’, was sandwiched ‘between the foundation of the Indian National Congress in 1885 and the achievement of independence in 1947’, since those 60 years ‘witnessed perhaps the greatest transition in our country’s long history’. In one memorable sentence, he signalled the many unfulfilled promises of Indian nationalism: thus, the Mahatma succeeded in ‘drawing in the masses, while at the same time keeping mass activity strictly pegged down to certain forms predetermined by the leader’.

Let me not dwell on the gaping hole that Sarkar’s demise had left among historians, and focus instead on the riches he has left us. His book, *Swadeshi Movement in Bengal*, on Bengal’s (first) partition of 1905, and the nationalist

movement that it spawned, was full of methodological innovations, using plays, novels, newspapers, pamphlets, in addition to the more familiar colonial archive. These materials led him to ask questions that often led to ambiguous or unsatisfactory answers. Educated unemployment and rising prices surely fuelled the anger against the Bengal partition. But the pride-inducing victory of a little ‘eastern’ nation, Japan, over a powerful ‘western’ neighbour, Russia, – the Russo-Japanese war of 1904-05 – also played its part, despite a relative ignorance in India of emerging critiques of imperialism elsewhere.

Sarkar also asked himself: how could a Swadeshi editorial in the *Bande Mataram* praise, in the same breath, both the labour movement and the caste system, the latter for having had ‘the true socialistic aim of keeping awake in ev-



Legacy unmatched: Historian Sumit Sarkar passed away on August 13. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ery class of society a sense of duty to it’? Or, as he would ask later, what drew upper caste men to revolutionary terrorism in Bengal, and why has that memory endured longer than those of tribal or lower caste participants?

He was among the earliest of historians to unpack how ‘Hindu’ nationalism gradually became ‘common sense’, with consequences up to this day.

Sarkar’s task was to break out of the economic determinism and narrow

positivism that was the hallmark of Marxist scholarship at the time. But the work remains unsurpassed, since it upholds the protocols of historical research, the verifiability of evidence, and as he said, ‘the constant knowledge that my conclusions remain open to revision and change’. Would a revised Modern India, that more correctly reflects the scholarship of the last four decades – as many regions, social groups, practices, and events have found

their historians – be at all possible in our times? How were material conditions and cultural forms to be integrated within a structured totality?

His Marxism did not come in the way of engaging with what Ranajit Guha has called the oldest (and richest) archive in India: religion. He read religion, but not as a believer; not to denigrate but to connect the celestial world to its earthly presence in meaningful ways.

In fact, Marxism enabled his interest in the 19th-century mystic (and rustic) Hindu thinker Ramakrishna Paramhansa, and the petty-bourgeois, clerical ambience within which he operated, which gave his philosophy its force and material influence, especially among the emerging, well-read, urban middle class. That contradiction needed to be explained. Sarkar linked the belated entry of clock-time into India, and the

disciplinary mechanisms it generated, to the slavery of clerical labour, which paved the way for the reception of Ramakrishna.

On RSS and Left

Sarkar showed us the true meaning of engaged scholarship: when India was stunned in 1992 by the shock troops of the BJP and RSS that brought down the Babri Masjid, Sarkar and his colleagues produced a short but vital book called *Khaki Shorts and Saffron Flags*. It was the first serious historical reconstruction (based also on sensitive fieldwork) of what the RSS had become, the most formidable force on the Indian political firmament. Certainly the young people who have today given us a ray of hope should place this book at the top of their reading lists.

Sarkar, in both his writing and his political positions, was unafraid to confront the official Left and its surrender to global cap-

ital, as at Nandigram and Singur. He would have been the first to admit that proletarians have not been the grave diggers of capitalism, though he welcomed historians who showed renewed interest in labour and working class history.

I was personally honoured when this remarkable historian included me in his review of five such books. But more striking was his intellectual openness: his choices ‘provincialised’ Bengal, by acknowledging the worlds and questions that lay well beyond it – Kanpur, Jamshedpur, KGF, Bombay, the railway works.

At a time when ‘everyone’ is a historian, and we are being trained in thinking of history only as ‘pride’ in the past, we will miss complex thinkers like Sarkar even more, for his passing no doubt signals the end of an era.

(Janaki Nair is the professor (retd), Centre for Historical Studies, JNU)

SUDOKU

8 3 9 7 1 4 2 5 6 2 6 4 8 1 5 3 2 6 3 7 8 5

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Two forms of worship

In the Bhagavad Gita, Canto 12 is dedicated to Bhakti Yoga, the yoga of devotion, said Sri Ramanujamiji in a discourse. There are two primary forms of worship and meditation in Hindu philosophy – *Saguna Upasana* (manifestation form) and *Nirguna Upasana* (formless devotion). *Saguna* worship refers to devotion with attributes or with qualities, whereas *Nirguna Upasana* means devotion without attributes or formless devotion. In the Bhagavad Gita, Arjuna asks Lord Krishna which of the two paths is superior. Lord Krishna replies to Arjuna that while both paths ultimately lead to the same Supreme realisation, *Saguna Upasana*, devotion in personal form, is far easier and more practical for embodied human beings. This forms the foundational essence of Bhakti Yoga. He also explains that *Nirguna Upasana* represents a profound philosophical realisation and is exceptionally difficult for common people because the human mind and intellect naturally rely on names and forms, and need a physical sensory focus.

Saguna dhyana enhances the essence of *nirguna*. Take gold as an example: a solid bar of gold (*nirguna*) versus an intricately crafted wearable golden ornament (*saguna*). Similarly, water in a still, silent lake (*nirguna*), versus a beautifully flowing waterfall that brings joy through its movement and sound (*saguna*). Ultimately, both *saguna* and *nirguna Upasana* are two sides of the same coin, which are inseparable. *Saguna* has the added advantage of letting devotees connect emotionally, whether they view the divine as a master, a friend, a child, a beloved, or their own soul, allowing them to pray, seek compassion, and be guided.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14874

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at https://thehindu.com/crosswords

13 Practical joke from knight in park roundabout (5)

15 Poor vets travel and stay overnight (4,4)

17 Rose awkwardly holding dress and strings of beads for prayer (8)

19 Yankee following Lord is before time (5)

22 What a snake might do in barn? (4)

23 Cleared tee by mistake? Slow down! (10)

26 Author's poem is in Welsh residence (9)

27 Perspired, removing pips and made mistake (5)

28 Learnt how I'm confused about spouse's mummy (6-2-3)

Down

1 Biggles' plane, perhaps, arrived at port (5)

2 Perhaps, Norse monk is not a cigar or cigarette user (3-6)

3 Having title, wrongly won gin cocktail (6)

4 Increase soldiers in month with initial threat (7)

5 A small quantity from Anzio tavern (4)

6 African flower produced by Vernier travelling around '49 (4,5)

7 Admits, "Won wrongly by tailless cat when going back" (4,2)

8 Drug addict, perhaps, from a vehicle at Emergency Room (6)

14 Dreamt SAM exploded in city (9)

16 Baked food with church male is cut bit by bit (9)

17 About female animal getting small plants once again (6)

18 Sign and kill (7)

20 Returns damaged lid? Yes! (6)

21 Arabian, perhaps, one following enemy running away (6)

24 A f-fight to get something to use with a bow (5)

25 Tea, I hear, followed tea in discussion (4)

Your portfolio without you

Vaishali R. Venkat

Imagine you are stranded in a desert with no broker’s app, no Internet. Buying/selling shares or mutual funds is out of the question. You can’t even check your investments.

“So what?” you may ask. “It is only a matter of a few hours.” But what if you stay there for a fortnight? You somehow learn to survive, perhaps by imitating a camel. Fortunately, the camel has no portfolio to worry about; its life is free from market crashes, share-price swings and needs no Internet or broker’s app.

Managing portfolio

You, however, have spent years carefully building a retirement portfolio. Now comes the acid test: what happens when you are not there to manage it? A crisis such as Chennai’s December 2015 deluge, the massive Spain-Portugal power outage of April 2025, or even a prolonged technological disruption can suddenly cut you off from financial life, leaving your own money beyond your reach.

There was also an unverified account doing the rounds on social media of an investor, unable to access their portfolio during the blackout, reportedly ‘travelled’ nearly 2,000 km from Madrid to Italy to execute trade.

Whether the story is true or not, that’s beyond our purview now. But, imagine crossing a border and travelling that far, just to reach your own investments and execute a single trade. Which brings us to the real question: if you cannot reach your portfolio for a couple of weeks, can the portfolio still do its job?

More vulnerable

A portfolio that requires you to watch it every day is vulnerable to more than just market volatility. A vacation abroad, hospitalisation, prolonged power cut owing to floods or natural disasters, lost phone, Internet outage, a few days of inattention or simply a few days away from the screen can have financial consequences, especially a loss. The Madrid investor’s story, whether true or not, is an extreme illustration: if being unable to press a button can force you to change your travel plans, perhaps the investment is demanding too much from its owner.

Swing trading

For instance, this is where swing trading often gets mistaken for investing. An investor may buy shares expecting to hold them for years, sometimes decades, to build wealth for life after retirement; a swing trader may buy them expecting to sell after a quicker price move over days or weeks. Neither is inherently wrong. But the second strategy makes access and timing part of the game. If you are stranded without a phone when the price reaches the level at which you intended to sell, your absence suddenly matters. That is not necessarily a bad strategy; it is simply a strategy that cannot be treated as a set-and-forget investment. It is not an investment at all in the first place.

Try this with your portfolio: mentally switch off your phone, Internet and broker account for a fortnight. Then look at each of your investments and ask this question: “What happens if I do nothing for a month?” If the answer is “nothing”, that may be a good sign. If the answer is “I must monitor, renew, switch, sell or make a decision”, you have discovered something important about the investment, and about your dependence on it.

The distinction is simple: some investments can patiently wait for you; others have a clock ticking in your absence. If an investment depends on you spotting a price, pressing a button or taking a decision at precisely the right time, your absence becomes a risk in itself. A long-term portfolio should ideally have fewer such moving parts. You may be away from your portfolio; your portfolio should not be away from its purpose. Think about it.

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



One more: Another unseen benefit is ‘lifelong renewability’ of hospitalisation policies.GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Think before you don’t renew your policy!

We tend to value visible rewards while renewing an insurance policy but rights and benefits accumulated over time, though invisible until you need them, can be far more valuable

BETWEEN THE LINES

K. Nitya Kalyani

She was insured for 11 years with not a single hospitalisation claim but no premium discount in appreciation of a profitable customer was forthcoming. So, my friend did not renew her hospitalisation policy.

Mistake. One because she did not have a fallback policy. But, more so because, in this policy, she had accumulated something. In fact, a goldmine of invisible benefits.

The policy had accrued the maximum bonus sum insured possible due to all those claim-free years. That is, instead of a cash discount, she had been given extra insurance value for the same premium.

She had also availed periodic free or subsidised master health check-ups through the years. And her time-bound exclusions were exclusions no more since the waiting periods were long over.

Expanded coverage

In other words, the scope of her coverage had expanded over time as she persisted with the policy.

We tend to value visible rewards. But rights and benefits accumulated over time, though invisible until you need them, can be far more valuable. Not for nothing is insurance called an intangible product. It is not just a money equation

Not for nothing is insurance called an intangible product. It is not just a money equation of premium and claims. It’s something more

of premium and claims.

Lifelong renewability

Another unseen benefit is ‘lifelong renewability’ of hospitalisation policies.

Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), the insurance sector regulator, has made this mandatory for standard hospitalisation policies without fresh medical tests.

Accordingly, your insurance company cannot refuse renewal or hike your individual premium due to your health setbacks or claims provided you have paid your premiums on time and kept the policy active.

Exceptions are cases such as proven fraud, intentional misrepresentation, false claims, moral hazard and so on.

All these benefits and the real downside of difficulties in getting new policies as age advances makes a strong case for not throwing the baby out with the bathwater.

I only wish this friend had called before her renewal or even during the grace period. She could have kept her coverage and

The various benefits and the real downside of difficulties in getting new policies as age advances makes a strong case for not throwing the baby out with the bathwater

her well-earned benefits intact. She did contact the insurer a couple of months later to renew but it was a no go. And that is as per hospitalisation policy norms.

Losing all

Misreading, or not reading, her policy was a mistake. A bigger misstep was letting it lapse and losing it all. Both she and her agent lost something of value.

She lost her coverage; the agent lost a sale and a customer. He ought to have told her what she stood to lose. The lesson? You may have doubts and questions about the value of your insurance policy, but don’t throw it away without an expert once-over.

Now, all I could tell her was to buy a policy afresh and start from square one. Harder when you are 11 years older.

Since you will be assessed anew, health status could have deteriorated and higher risk levels perceived making underwriting more difficult. They may offer you restricted cover and higher premium. Medical tests will almost certainly be required

and certain risks can even be declined citing age and company guidelines.

You have to go through the waiting periods for pre-existing diseases all over again and there could be more of them.

Ditto for waiting periods for specified procedures and day-care surgeries. You will have to go through claim-free years again for the bonus in the form of extra sum insured to start accruing.

The Tirukkural says it best: Think before you act; there is little point in deliberating afterwards.

And this is not just about hospitalisation insurance. There are plenty of insurance decisions, acts of omission and commission, that people come to regret. I will share some of those stories in the next instalment of Between the Policy Lines.

What you are letting go

- 1) Accumulated bonuses
- 2) Waiting periods for excluded coverage
- 3) Right to renew
- 4) Loyalty and continuity benefits such as free medical check-ups and access to health and fitness apps/ trackers
- 5) Anchor policy to increase sum insured
- 6) Base policy to build coverage with a top-up or super top up
- 7) Track record with the insurer and relationships built

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

Convertible, portable?

THINKINVESTOR

If you are likely to continually experience work-related relocation, then you must consider investing primarily in financial assets; buying land must be to park surplus cash, not to achieve life goal

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

The asset allocation process helps you determine how much of your savings must be allocated to each asset class. If you were to invest only in financial assets, then the process typically involves deciding how much to invest in equity and bonds. But what if you want to invest in physical assets such as real estate and commodity (read gold)? In this article, we discuss the temptation to invest in physical assets and the factors you must be mindful of before allocating your annual savings to such assets.

Investment portability

Physical assets are touch-and-feel investments, unlike financial assets that are abstract. This is a tempting benefit, as it is easy to relate to a touch-and-feel asset. Also, if these investments do not increase significantly in value, you can always convert them into consumption asset.

Take land. If you are unable to sell land at a higher price, you can build a house for self-occupation. Likewise, you can convert your physical gold bar into jewellery if the investment does not fetch good returns.

Flip side

There is the flip side to investing in physical assets. What if your work requires you to move from one city to another or from State to another? Your real estate is not portable; financial assets are. Also, it takes some effort to convert physical gold into cash. In addition, you need a safe place to store your gold and bank lockers are not easily available. Note that portability of your gold investments (taking gold with you when you relocate) depends on your ability to rent bank lockers or alternative safe storage facilities.

Conclusion

If you are likely to continually experience work-related relocation, then you must consider investing primarily in financial assets. This is not to say that you should not invest in land. But your investment in land must be to park surplus cash and not to achieve a life goal. This is because real estate investment is not liquid. That means you may be unable to convert your investment into cash at a fair price when you need the money to achieve a life goal. Note that Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) are not a pure bet on real estate. That is, REITs are exposed to market risk, as they are listed on a stock exchange. So, their prices can decline when the market tanks. That said, REITs could be an optimal alternative to lumpy investments in real estate to earn rental income.

(The author offers training programs for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

* Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.13-11.65	10,169 - 11,029	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,647	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 4,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

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A Spanish fighter jet on Sunday shot down a drone that had breached Romanian airspace near the border with Ukraine and Moldova, national authorities and NATO said. The interception of the drone — which entered from Moldova — was carried out by an F-18. Debris fell in an unpopulated area of the Galati region. AFP

Israel's Defence Minister Israel Katz vowed on Sunday it would hit Hezbollah again if threatened, as it identified what it described as a commander killed in strikes a day earlier that also left several children dead. Israeli strikes on Saturday killed 11 people in south Lebanon, as per officials, in one of the deadliest attacks. AFP

U.S. negotiator and President Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner held a rare meeting with Hamas chief Khalil al-Hayya on Sunday in a new diplomatic effort to make progress in the stalled Gaza ceasefire. Mr. Kushner, along with Tony Blair and Nickolay Mladenov, will meet with Israel's Prime Minister on Monday. AP

Around 5,000 people have been evacuated after a magnitude-7.7 earthquake, the deadliest since 2022, rocked eastern Indonesia on Saturday, killing at least 53, blocking roads and causing landslides, authorities said on Sunday. They added that more than 130 people had been injured, many with broken bones. REUTERS

Whenever he gets a chance, he scores runs: Jurel praises Padikkal



Nuwantha is certainly one for the future, reckons Prabath



Bangladesh outplayed us in all facets: Australia skipper Cummins



It's inevitable Australia has to make changes: Ponting after shock loss



Padikkal, Jurel consolidate Team India's position

Bangladesh earns maiden Test victory in Australia

A photograph of two Sri Lankan cricketers in white uniforms celebrating on a green field. The player on the left is wearing a white cap and sunglasses, and the player on the right is wearing a white shirt with red accents. They are both running and cheering, with their arms raised in celebration.

Biggest win in Bangladesh's history, says proud Shanto

"As I said before this Test match, we wanted to play five days of good cricket, so nothing has changed. Going into the next Test, we need to follow the process, accept the challenges and enjoy those. Australia has a quality bowling attack, so we have to play good cricket again. As a bowling unit, we have to be disciplined again," the skipper added.



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SL. No.	Open Tender No.	Short Description of Work	Approx. Value in ₹	Date of Tender Closing Date & Time
1	2026377 212323	(A) New Raw & Metro Water Pipelines: East Colony to Furnishing Factory & Main Pump House to Block 165 (B) Repairs to leakages in GLR & OHT and interconnection of pump houses in South colony. (C) New GLR & OHT in South colony (D) 3.00 Lakh GLR in East colony- 2Nos (E) OHT & GLR in Shell Factory (F) Reconstruction of 3 Lakh litres capacity at GLR in East Colony - 2 Nos	₹ 5.93/- crores	04.09.2026 @ 10.30 hrs

Hindi version of the above advertisement is available in the website: www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in/



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2026440 212294	Works contract of "Comprehensive Annual Maintenance contract (CAMC) of Horizontal Drilling & Tapping Machine-Iny No.2192 available in Shop 12 of Shell Division, ICF for a period of three years.	₹ 63,40,653/-	31.08.2026 15.00 Hours
20264762 12078RT2	Reconditioning of Grit Blasting Plant-Iny. No. 2517 available in Shop-23 of Shell division/ICF	₹ 58,25,562/-	31.08.2026 15.00 Hours

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Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer / Plant



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Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer (Construction) Western Railway, DRM Office Annex Building 3rd Floor Do Batti, Ratlam (M.P.) 457001, invites **Tender Notice No.: ELC-RTM-2026-07-T, Date: 13.08.2026. Name of Work:** Modification, design, laying and commissioning of HT & LT Electrical crossings/ line infringements in the section of Godhra- Ratlam, in connection with Vadodara - Ratlam section Quadrupling project of Ratlam Division, Western Railways. **Approx Value:** ₹ 6,63,63,506.87. **Bid Deposit:** ₹ 13,27,300/- **Online Bidding Start Date:** 28.08.2026. **Tender Closing Date:** On 11.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. For further details please visit our website www.ireps.gov.in **0482**

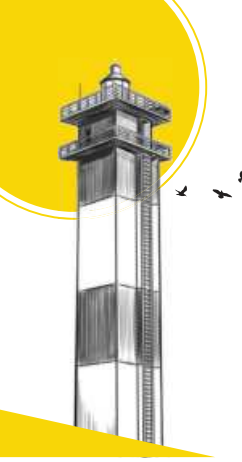
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3. Which Chennai cultural institution's annual LangFest, first held in 2021, explored the theme "Histories in Plural" in its sixth edition?

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Mamidala Jagadesh Kumar

India's higher education system faces two challenges at once. A qualification earned in one part of the country should be recognised and respected elsewhere but the education offered must also be relevant to its students, languages, social setting, and surrounding economy. These aims may appear to pull in different directions. In practice, they can reinforce each other.

This balance is the essence of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. It calls for careful planning, joint monitoring, and collaboration between the Centre and the States, supports institutional autonomy and the expansion of programmes in local languages, and provides meaningful room for State priorities and local aspirations.

Guidelines

National frameworks provide broad guidelines to the institutions without imposing rigid prescriptions. For instance, the UGC framework leaves important academic decisions to institutional statutory bodies. NEP 2020 seeks to remove rigid separations among arts, sciences and vocational learning while preserving disciplinary depth. New interdisciplinary programmes can build confidence over time alongside established ones. Institutions are best placed to undertake this patient work.

Recent commentary on

Build the right connections

Strengthening institutional capacity, measuring outcomes reliably and using better regional data can create more opportunities for all learners

GETTY IMAGES/JSTOCKPHOTO

regional higher-education needs has rightly emphasised that admission patterns must be understood in their regional context. This local perspective can work within, rather than against, a national framework for academic mobility. Such data can reveal demand within a particular institution or region but they must be interpreted carefully.

A student's choice is also an exercise of agency. Career information should broaden that choice, not prescribe a single "correct" course based on short-term market trends. The All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) 2023-24 records 4.50 crore students, compared with 3.42 crore in 2014-15. Over the same period, the gross enrolment ratio for the 18-23 age group rose from 23.7 to 30.

Beyond course preferences, institutional reputation will continue to influence student decisions. Reputation may reflect teaching and research, but also history, location, alumni, programme range, and public visibility. A constructive approach is to widen the number of institutions that students and families can choose with confidence.

Student mobility

At the same time, local relevance should not confine a learner to the place of study. The National Credit Framework and the Academic Bank of Credits seek to make academic, vocational and experiential learning recognisable and portable across institutions and States. Institutions must ensure that credits are accurately recorded,

transferred, and redeemed to enable students to complete their programmes promptly. When these arrangements work well, portability and place-based learning support student mobility.

A related question concerns the relationship between curriculum and employment. Degrees cannot be designed only around immediate job openings because economies and occupations change. Higher education must build knowledge, judgement, communication, creativity, and the capacity to learn and give students opportunities to apply those capabilities in professional, social, and community settings. NEP 2020's emphasis on multidisciplinary learning, internships, vocational exposure and local opportunity mapping brings these purposes together.

The UGC's guidance enables institutions to develop internship projects suited to their academic programmes and the surrounding economic environment. Its university-industry framework encourages regional clusters, Industry Relations Cells and engagement with micro, small, and medium enterprises. Apprenticeship-embedded degree programmes and Profes-

sors of Practice provide further channels for professional participation. AICTE's model curricula and applied-learning initiatives similarly connect technical education with projects, internships and emerging fields.

Accordingly, we should continue to build a stronger evidence base linking education to opportunity. From graduating students, institutes could collect information on employment, further study, entrepreneurship, location, wages, and the use of skills at suitable intervals after graduation, while respecting privacy issues. They should also present student-facing programme information, such as curriculum, costs, eligibility, accreditation, internships, completion, and possible pathways, in clear language, without making predictive promises. States and regional skills centres could bring together official labour data, apprenticeship information, industry evidence and institutional records.

Ultimately, India needs a connected education system in which qualifications are recognised across regions. Institutions should adapt to local needs, while students should be free to choose their learning pathways. We should continue to strengthen institutional capacity, measure outcomes reliably and use better regional data.

Views are personal

The writer is the Chairman of the Review Committee for NEP 2020 and Chairman, BoG, IIM-Cuttack.



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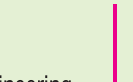
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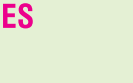
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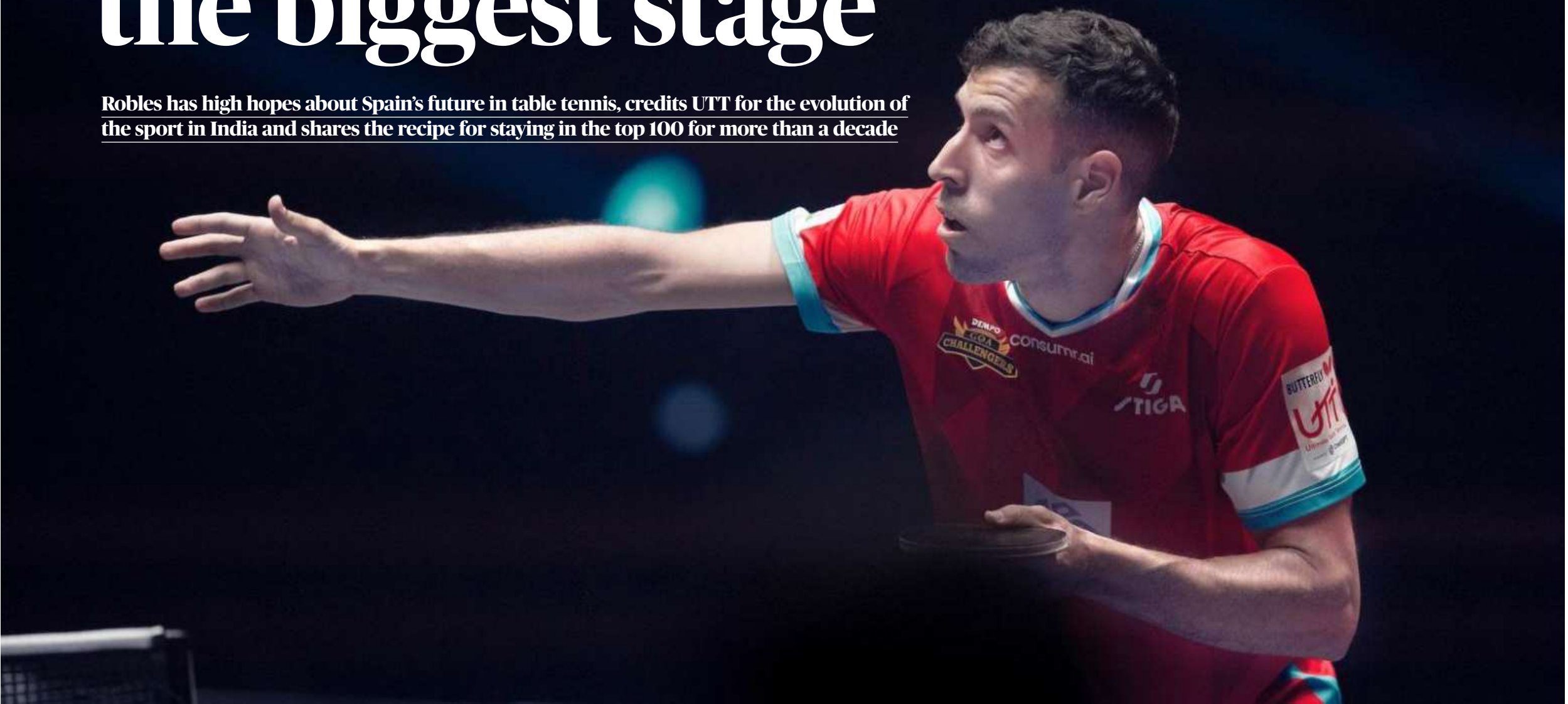
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The Olympics is always the biggest stage

Robles has high hopes about Spain's future in table tennis, credits UTT for the evolution of the sport in India and shares the recipe for staying in the top 100 for more than a decade



BUTTERFLY UTT

INTERVIEW

Alvaro Robles

Amol Karhadkar

For more than a decade, Alvaro Robles has been a regular presence on the international table tennis circuit. The Spanish left-hander, who has reached a career-high No. 28 in the world, has spent nearly 10 years inside the top 100 and is now a familiar face in the Ultimate Table Tennis, having featured in six of the seven editions.

Robles' journey, however, began with an unlikely idol: Timo Boll. As a teenager in Spain, he watched videos of the German great and began copying his game before eventually moving to Germany to train alongside some of the world's best.

That decision, he says, shaped not only his table tennis but also his personality.

Now a father of two, Robles continues to juggle the demands of a professional career with family life while trying to earn another shot at the Olympics.

In an interaction with *The Hindu*, he spoke about Boll, his move to Germany, the evolution of Spanish table tennis, longevity in the sport, UTT's impact on Indian table tennis and his desire to feature in another Olympics. Excerpts:

You have spoken about Boll being one of your idols. How did that fascination begin?

I started watching him when I was 16 or 17. He was in his prime and I watched so many of his matches. I took a lot of motivation from his game. I think my style is quite similar to his.

Was there a particular moment that got you hooked to his style?

What I remember most is that when I was 16 or 17, we started getting access to computers and I watched the first videos on YouTube. I was very impressed. I started copying him in practice and tried to take every skill from him as a left-hander. As you said, it was natural for many lefties to copy Boll.

You then moved to Germany. Did you get an opportunity to interact with him?

Not very often, but a few times. I played against him and practised with him. It was a privilege to share those moments with somebody I really admired. I could never beat him – he was so good – but I managed to have some close matches. I was very happy about that.

How much did moving to Germany transform your career?

It had a huge impact on my career and table tennis. I got to know the best players in the world and learnt more about training systems, how other players think and what mentality is required to reach the top.

How difficult was it as a teenager to take that decision?

It was a difficult choice. When you decide to move, you don't know the consequences or what you will face. But it was a beautiful journey to discover. If I look back, I would do it again. I met people from all around the world... different countries and cultures. I am really happy to have experienced that kind of life.

Was it tough for your family to understand why you wanted to move to Germany?

In Spain, there was not much of a tradition for table tennis. My parents supported me, but I am not sure they knew exactly what kind of future I would have. I am grateful for their support and the freedom they gave me because that allowed me to develop my career, my personality and my character. I discovered so much about myself during that journey.

How much has Spanish table tennis changed over the last two decades?

It has developed a lot. I think we have been very successful in improving the medium level of players. Now we have around 20 players competing at a very similar level. They are not yet at the top level, but many are between 100 and 300 in the world and can compete really well.

The next step is obviously to have more players inside the top 100. But even at the base, we have some amazing under-13, under-15 and under-17 players achieving unbelievable international results.

If a Spanish teenager came to you today saying he wanted to make a career in table tennis, what would you tell him?

First, it is very important to understand the background of each player – where they come from, which club they belong to, how old they are and what they want to achieve. Everyone is individual and different. That is the first thing I would observe before giving any advice. I would like to know the background of each player so I can help them better.

You have spent almost a decade in the world's top 100. How demanding is that consistency?

It is very demanding. For 10 years I have been inside the top 100, and it costs a lot. In my case, the secret is consistency in the work. I thought about my practice, physical condition and performance every day. I was worried about improving every day

and maybe that is why I have remained around the top 50. Now I am No. 67, but before the Olympics, I reached No. 28, which was great for my career. I keep thinking every day about how I can return to my best shape. I hope I can remain at this level for another 10 years.

Players are now extending their careers well into their late 30s and 40s. How has that become possible?

A few things have changed. There are now many opportunities to continue playing WTT events and league matches. There are great leagues where players can earn an income. To perform for many years, there is much more information about taking care of yourself – nutrition, physical preparation and psychology. Earlier, many players didn't have access to so much information.

Because of this, we feel better with our bodies, play with fewer injuries and continue believing that we can play at 38, 40 or 42. Then it comes down to your mental approach, motivation, circumstances, family and how long you want to keep travelling. Look at Robert Gardos, who is 47 and still performing extremely well. That is impressive, but it is also because he takes great care of himself.

How would you compare the support structure in Spain with countries such as Germany or Sweden, or India?

Support is not only about money. For me, support means having a structure of coaches and people who help develop the sport – physical trainers, analysts, physiotherapists and people guiding players towards their maximum potential.

Sometimes we are confused. Support is not simply 'I give you

money and then you do what you want.' Support is creating a structure that helps a group reach its potential. That is what is improving now.

How difficult is it to balance travelling for seven months a year with family life?

It is difficult. I have travelled abroad for six or seven months a year, and it is hard when you know your family is at home. My children are young and they miss me.

We try to manage the logistics so they can come to some tournaments. My daughter came to the World Championships in Doha last year and they came to a Contender in Macedonia. That gives me energy because being away from home for so many weeks is difficult. Bringing them with me and having them around gives me motivation to keep trying for my best results.

How has fatherhood changed the approach to your career?

Totally. Even though I thought I would manage it one way, everything changed because the feelings are different. Suddenly, you have to face things you are not prepared for and manage them with your wife and family.

I think that it has been the biggest work I have had to do in recent years – more than table tennis: learning how to handle family life with professional life.

You have been part of UTT for six seasons. How have you seen the league evolve?

Quite well. The idea was to create a league where foreign players could bring experience to Indian table tennis. Now you see how much Indian table tennis has grown. It is crazy.

If you compare 2018 with 2026, you can now see how many Indian players are in the top 100, top 50 and top 40. Youngsters play as if they have 20 years of experience.

Earlier, you didn't see that. Now there are many of them.

That has come from the investment and effort of the federation and the people who wanted to create the league. It is very impressive. You see youngsters such as Syndrela Das, who was watching from the stands when she was 11 or 12, now playing against players like Manika Batra and even beating them. That comes from a country's big effort to develop a sport.

What do you enjoy doing away from table tennis?

I love sport. I like playing tennis, padel and football. All my hobbies are related to sport. Going out with my wife when the kids are not with us is also something I enjoy – going on holiday after many months of hard work. That is how I switch off and recharge.

You have won a World championship doubles silver and a European mixed doubles gold. What remains the biggest target?

The European championship gold in mixed doubles is a great achievement because, at the end, it is a gold medal. It is very special to me. But the Olympics is always the biggest stage. Everything I am doing is aimed at getting that experience one more time. I know winning an Olympic medal is something really, really difficult... on another level.

But I try to find my best version and keep the opportunity open. You never know. I will keep fighting to be there and give my best version one more time.



Scientists find why an enervating disorder affects only Eurasians

The Nizam's Institute of Medical Sciences in Hyderabad, diagnoses one case of Friedrich's ataxia every month on average — and almost all of these individuals come from consanguineous marriages, according to medical geneticist Ashwin Dalal

D.P. Kasbekar

Friedrich's ataxia, or FRDA, is a genetic disorder that progressively damages the nerves and the heart. The affected individuals typically begin to show symptoms between the ages of 5 and 15. They become unsteady and their coordination is impaired. Their speech slows down and slurs. Swallowing becomes difficult. Hearing and vision deteriorates. They feel fatigued, lose sensation, first in the arms and legs, then in the trunk and other parts of the body, and the spine curves to one side. Eventually, most patients die relatively young, of heart disease. There is no cure. According to Ashwin Dalal, a medical geneticist at the Nizam's Institute of Medical Sciences in Hyderabad, the institute diagnoses one case of FRDA every month on average — and almost all of these individuals come from consanguineous marriages. That is, marriages between relatives, such as uncles and nieces, or between cousins. Many Indian communities practise consanguinity — and it greatly increases the risk of genetic diseases that are otherwise rare. Friedrich's ataxia is one such disease. Curiously, so far, FRDA has not been reported in people from sub-Saharan Africa, North America, and China, Japan, and Southeast Asia. For a long time, scientists have only found it in individuals of European, North African, West Asian, and South Asian descent. A new study from researchers at the University of Oklahoma Health Sciences Center in the U.S. has finally cracked the puzzle. Their findings were reported in June 9 in the journal *Human Molecular Genetics*.

Inefficient powerhouses
FRDA is caused when a gene called *FXN* becomes mutated. The *FXN* gene codes for a protein called frataxin. Frataxin is essential for mitochondria, which are our cells' powerhouses. The chemical ATP, which is the cell's energy currency, is made mostly in the mitochondria. Nerve, spinal cord, brain, and heart muscle cells use a lot of energy. When their frataxin levels become abnormally low, the mitochondria produce ATP less effectively and also accumulate toxic by-products. This renders the cell dysfunctional, leading to the symptoms of FRDA. The most common disease-causing mutations occur in a part of the *FXN* gene called the intron. A mutation takes the form of modifying the number of times a particular sequence of bases is repeated in the intron. Normal variants of the *FXN* gene contain 5-11 or 12-33 repeats. They're called the short normal and long normal



For a long time, scientists found FRDA in individuals of European, North African, West Asian, and South Asian descent. GETTY IMAGES (REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE)

variants. The short-normal variant is common in Europe and South Asia (85-90% of the population), sub-Saharan Africa (90%), and East Asia (over 99%). The long-normal variants are absent in East Asia and make up most of the rest in sub-Saharan Africa and in Europe and South Asia. However, the DNA sequences of people with Friedrich's ataxia revealed their *FXN* alleles variants had 100-1,500 repeats. The researchers called them expanded variants. The short-normal and long-normal variants have an open structure in the chromosome that allows cells to make frataxin as needed. However, the expanded variants forced the chromosome to assume a closed shape that reduced frataxin expression. Individuals who develop Friedrich's ataxia carry two copies of the expanded variant, one from each parent. A person with only one copy is called a carrier. Even though they themselves won't have the disease, carriers can pass their defective introns to their children. Fortunately, genetic tests can find out if a person is a carrier and whether they passed their extended variant to their children.

From mutation to disease
The researchers also found that 95% of the expanded variants of the intron originally came from just two long-normal variants. Specifically, they reported that at two times in history, a long-normal variant mutated to an extended variant,

These findings will help scientists understand what makes the two protomutations different from other long-normal variants: this answer in turn will help find ways to prevent or at least slow down the genetic changes

both times in Eurasia. We don't know why these events happened nor why only long-normal variants mutated this way. We also don't know why this never happened in sub-Saharan Africa. On the other hand, the absence of long-normal variants in East Asian populations could explain why these problematic mutations didn't arise there. These originator mutations, which the researchers called protomutations, didn't straightaway lead to Friedrich's ataxia. Instead, they slowly but steadily changed into pre-mutations — where the number of repeats was abnormally high but not enough to significantly impair frataxin expression. The non-disease-causing but still abnormal pre-mutations turned into an extended variant in a sudden burst of repeat expansion in a single or few parent-to-child transmissions. Recall that people with Friedrich's ataxia die earlier. So over time, the extended variants disappear from the population. People with protomutations and pre-mutations on the other hand did not present that risk. As a result, they

acted as 'reservoirs' in the population that steadily replenished the depleting extended variants over time. Taken together, the patchy distribution of protomutations can explain why Friedrich's ataxia occurs only in some populations. The protomutations arose only a few times and only in populations with a sufficient number of the long-normal variants.

Ancient DNA
Finally, by analysing DNA from the skeletal remains of individuals who lived in ancient times, the researchers also found both the two protomutations were present in Europe and Western Asia at least 9,000 years ago. However, they were not seen in the Neanderthals and Denisovans. In a statement, research team leader Sanjay Bidichandani credited "the longstanding tradition in the human genetics community of freely sharing DNA sequence data" to be "crucial to accurately track the presence of susceptibility to Friedrich's ataxia from prehistoric humans to a wide variety of extant populations". These findings will help scientists understand what makes the two protomutations different from other long-normal variants that don't turn into pre-mutations. This answer in turn will help find ways to prevent or at least slow down the genetic changes. (D.P. Kasbekar is a retired scientist. kasbekardp@yahoo.co.in)

THE GIST

▼ So far, Friedrich's ataxia has not been reported in people from sub-Saharan Africa, North America, and China, Japan, and Southeast Asia

▼ A new study from researchers at the University of Oklahoma Health Sciences Center found that Friedrich's ataxia is caused when a gene called *FXN* becomes mutated

▼ The study found that patchy distribution of originator mutations, called protomutations, can explain why Friedrich's ataxia occurs only in some populations

BIG SHOT



Adult and immature blue-footed boobies rest on rocks near the entrance to the Panama Canal as seabirds native to the cold, nutrient-rich waters off Peru and Chile appear outside their usual range, while El Niño warms the eastern Pacific and disrupts marine food supplies, off the coast of Panama City on August 5. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Hara mangrove forests

Vasudevan Mukunth

The Hara forests are a vital ecological treasure of the Persian Gulf. Spanning the Strait of Hormuz, these mangrove forests consist mainly of grey mangrove trees (*Avicennia marina*), which have a special filtration system in their roots that allows them to thrive in saline conditions. The same roots also protect the coast against erosion and are voluminous carbon sinks, sequestering significantly more carbon than terrestrial forests. The forests are a UNESCO Biosphere Reserve and serve as an important nursery for marine life as they shelter shrimp, crabs, and numerous fish species that sustain the region's fisheries. Up from the water's edge, the Hara forests' canopy is also a major migratory hub for birds like the great stone-curlew and various herons. The mangroves are the backbone of the sustainable tourism programmes of Qeshm, an Iranian island in the Persian Gulf, and draw visitors to their labyrinthine waterways. Protecting these forests is crucial for the lives and livelihoods of Qeshm's local communities and for efforts to preserve the Gulf's natural heritage. Environmentalists have said losing them would trigger a catastrophic collapse of the local food chain and coastal defenses.



A satellite image shows Qeshm Island following an oil spill at sea, off the coast of Iran, on August 10, 2026. REUTERS

Recent satellite images have revealed a major environmental threat to just these forests: an oil spill off Qeshm's southern coast. Experts have identified the source to be a bulk carrier named Minoan Pioneer, which has been leaking heavy fuel oil after being struck by a projectile. The slick stretches 160 km long, with dark liquid already washing ashore. The ongoing West Asia conflict is also hindering cleanup efforts, leaving the mangroves at great risk of devastation.



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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Area affected by Belgium wildfire since Friday

3,000 in hectares. A wildfire raging in a nature reserve in eastern Belgium, the biggest to hit the country in recent history, has more than doubled in size in 24 hours to affect some 3,000 hectares, authorities said on Sunday. The Wallonia regional government said that over 250 emergency personnel were mobilised. AFP

Persons killed in Israeli strikes in southern Lebanon

11 Israel vowed on Sunday it would hit Hezbollah again if threatened, as it identified what it described as a commander killed in strikes a day earlier that also left several children dead. Israeli strikes on Saturday killed 11 people in southern Lebanon, according to authorities, in the deadliest attacks since a deal was reached in June aimed at ending hostilities. AFP

Roads blocked in Himachal Pradesh due to torrential rains

118 Torrential rains in Himachal Pradesh have led to the closure of 118 roads across the State, as the local meteorological office issued an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rains at isolated places in five districts on Monday and Tuesday. Dharamshala recorded 96.2 mm of rainfall, followed by Palampur at 55 mm and Kangra at 34.6 mm. PTI

Students stranded as floodwaters enter school in Odisha

400 Around 400 students, including 150 girls, were left stranded at a government-run residential school in Odisha's Kendrapara district after floodwater entered the campus on Sunday, an official said. The school is located in a low-lying area at Kulasahi village under Penthapala gram panchayat in Pattamundai block. PTI

Aid trucks that entered Afghanistan via Pakistan

700 More than 700 trucks carrying international humanitarian aid arrived in Afghanistan via Pakistan despite a near-total closure of the land border between the two countries in October, the United Nations said Sunday. The convoy was carrying "food and other humanitarian items," a UN spokesperson said. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The federal dilemma of delimitation

The Centre made an oral assurance while introducing the Bill to increase Lok Sabha seats that each State's share would increase by 50% on a pro-rata basis. However, the increase could weaken the Rajya Sabha's role as a check on the Lower House, while the Lok Sabha's limited sitting days would leave MPs with less time to raise issues

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly has passed a resolution urging the Centre to permanently freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at the existing number of 543 and maintain the present State-wise distribution of those seats. It also advocated the preservation of current ratio of 2.2:1 between Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha seats. It sought the implementation of one-third reservation of seats for women in the Lok Sabha from the 2029 election onwards, without linking it to any future census or delimitation.

Defining delimitation

Delimitation means the process of fixing the number of seats and boundaries of the territorial constituencies in each State for the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies. This 'Delimitation process' is performed by 'Delimitation Commission' that is set up under an act of Parliament. The last time when the number of seats were determined was on the basis of 1971 census population.

'Democracy' means 'rule or government by the people'. It follows that the government is elected by a majority with the broad principle of 'one citizen-one vote-one value'. Article 81(2) of the Constitution provides that the ratio between the number of seats and population of a State, shall as far as practicable be same for all the States. The number of seats in the Lok Sabha based on 1971 census was fixed at 543, when the population was 54.8 crores. This broadly translated to an average population of 10.1 lakhs per constituency. However, it has been frozen as per 1971 census in order to encourage population control measures so that States with higher population growth do not end up having higher number of seats. This was done through the 42nd Amendment Act till the year 2000 and was extended by the 84th amendment act till 2026. This number will have to be readjusted based on the first census after 2026 which would be the next census in 2027. In 2023, through the 106th Constitutional Amendment, the Parliament had provided for one-third reservation of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies. This would be through delimitation based on the census in 2027.

The issues involved

The population explosion that happened in our country during the last five decades has been uneven, with some States like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan witnessing a greater increase than States like Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh. The ratio between the current number of seats and the projected population of States as of 2026 does not satisfy the core democratic principle of 'one person-one vote-one value' (**Table 1**). On the other hand, the increase in the number of seats among various States based on the current population (to 848) is provided in **Table 2**. Southern States, smaller states in the North, as well as the North Eastern States, are bound to be at a disadvantage when compared to large north Indian States in such a scenario. This would be against the federal principles of our country. It also goes against the philosophy for freezing the seats as per 1971 census with the States

Representation imbalance

The redistribution of seats based on current population could put smaller and less populous States at a disadvantage



Table 1: Value of vote of each citizen based on estimated population as of 2026

State	Number of seats at present	Projected population as of 2026 (in crore)	Projected population per Lok Sabha seat (in lakh)	Value of 1 vote*
Uttar Pradesh	80	25.7	32.1	0.56
Bihar	40	13.5	33.8	0.53
Rajasthan	25	8.4	33.6	0.54
Madhya Pradesh	29	9.1	31.4	0.57
Tamil Nadu	39	7.8	20	0.9
Andhra Pradesh + Telangana	42	9.3	22.1	0.81
Kerala	20	3.6	18	1
Karnataka	28	6.9	24.6	0.73
Punjab	13	3.2	24.6	0.73
Himachal Pradesh	4	0.8	20	0.9
Uttarakhand	5	1.2	24	0.75

* Kerala calculated as 1 and States' values derived on this base

Table 2: If the number of seats is increased to 848 based on 2026 projected population

(Based on research paper of Milan Vaishnav and Jamie Hinton, for the Carnegie endowment)

State	Number of seats at present	Projected number of seats	Existing proportion	Revised proportion
Uttar Pradesh	80	143	14.7%	16.9%
Bihar	40	79	7.4%	9.3%
Rajasthan	25	50	4.6%	5.9%
Madhya Pradesh	29	52	5.3%	6.1%
Tamil Nadu	39	49	7.2%	5.8%
Andhra Pradesh + Telangana	42	54	7.7%	6.4%
Kerala	20	20	3.7%	2.4%
Karnataka	28	41	5.2%	4.8%
Punjab	13	18	2.4%	2.1%
Himachal Pradesh	4	4	0.7%	0.5%
Uttarakhand	5	7	0.9%	0.8%
Total	543	848		

that have been better at controlling the population losing out on their political significance.

Current proposal by the Centre

The Union government had introduced the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill in April 2026 to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from existing 550 to 850. The Home Minister made an oral assurance in the Parliament that the number of seats in each State/Union Territory would be increased by 50% on a pro-rata basis. However, this bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha. There are expectations that the government may introduce the bill again, in the near future with explicit provisions for 50% increase in seats for all States/Union Territories on a pro-rata basis.

The larger implications

The are two main arguments in support of the proposal for 50% pro-rata increase. First, it would not alter the current proportion of representation of various States/Union Territories in the Lok Sabha. Second, it would enable seamless reservation of one-third seats for women with the additional 272 seats being reserved for women out of the enlarged house of around 816 seats.

However, such an increase has its share of challenges. Firstly, the current strength of Rajya Sabha is 245 that results in a ratio of 2.2:1 between the total strength of Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha. An increase in Lok Sabha seats by 50% without altering seats in Rajya Sabha would skew this ratio to 3.3:1.

In the event of disagreement between the two houses on any bill, there is a mechanism for Joint Sitting under the Constitution to resolve the deadlock. Though used rarely in the past (only 3 times since Independence), this increased strength in the Lok Sabha runs the risk of rise in such joint sittings to push through Bills. In such a scenario, it would diminish the role of the Rajya Sabha as an effective check and balance on the Lok Sabha. Secondly, considering that the Lok Sabha sits for only around 60 days in a year, there would hardly be any meaningful time for each MP to raise their issues in the house. The purpose of the house would then be reduced to mere numerical representation rather than meaningful deliberation.

Finally, the increased cost to the exchequer because of additional MPs including allocation for the Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS) funds needs to be

borne in mind.

Harmonious reconciliation

The issue arises as the democratic and federal principles seem to be at loggerheads in the delimitation exercise as currently envisaged. However, they can be harmoniously reconciled by giving equal importance to both. The main work of a Member of Parliament is to legislate on the 'Union List' subjects such as defence, external affairs, railways, telecommunication, taxation etc. and hold the Central government accountable. A majority of the schemes of the Central Government are implemented only by the State governments. Hence, the number of MPs in Lok Sabha may be frozen at the present number of 543, which would ensure no disruption to the current representation of various States. This would maintain and uphold the federal principle. One-third reservation for women can be provided out of the existing 543 seats. The number of MLAs in each State may be increased in line with the current population to address the democratic representational requirement. (Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'. He currently trains at 'Officers IAS Academy'. Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

The Union government introduced the Constitution 131st Amendment Bill in April 2026 to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from the existing 550 to 850.

The Tamil Nadu Assembly recently passed a resolution urging the Centre to permanently freeze the number of Lok Sabha seats at 543 and maintain the present State-wise distribution of seats.

The ratio between the current number of seats and the projected population of States as of 2026 does not satisfy the principle of 'one person, one vote, one value'. However, increasing the number of seats based on current population would put smaller and less populous States at a disadvantage.

